The Economics of Abortion Policy

Damian Clarke, Economics, University of Chile, University of Exeter

https://doi.org/10.1093/acrefore/9780190625979.013.850
Published online: 18 June 2024

Summary

The economic literature on abortion policy broadly is broad, studying abortion reforms that have occurred over the past two centuries, with a concentration of studies examining policy reform over the 20th and 21st centuries. The literature has examined a range of policies: both those which restrict access and those which legalize elective abortion; but within these two broad classes, the precise nature of policy reform can vary greatly. Policy reforms studied range from specific types of limits or financial barriers restricting access for particular age groups to policies which entirely criminalize or legalize elective abortion. Policies have been studied that restrict or relax individual access as well as impose regulations on abortion providers. The economic literature on abortion reform has illuminated a number of clear links, showing that increased availability of abortion decreases rates of unintended births, and vice versa when access to abortion is limited. These effects have been shown to have downstream impacts in many domains such as family formation, educational attainment, and labor market attachment, as well as impacts on health, empowerment, and broader measures of well-being such as life satisfaction and exposure to intimate partner violence.

There is mixed evidence when examining the impact that abortion reform has on cohorts of children exposed to reform variation. Across contexts abortion reforms have been shown to affect the composition of cohorts of children via differential rates of access to abortion, though this compositional effect is context-dependent, and as such a number of different patterns have been documented. Compositional effects of policies often also have been shown to have a geographic component, given that certain types of individuals are more easily able to travel to access abortion where restrictions are in place in one area but not in another.

Much of what is known in the economic literature on abortion is gleaned from country-level case studies and cohort variation in access, with this evidence generated from a relatively small number of countries in which reforms have occurred and data is available. In general, much of the literature available covers low fertility and industrialized settings. Additional evidence from other settings would allow for a broader understanding of how abortion reform affects well-being.

Keywords: abortion, contraceptives, labor markets, fertility, child outcomes, crime, health, political economy

Subjects: Health, Education, and Welfare Economics, Labor and Demographic Economics, Law and Economics, Public Economics and Policy

Introduction

Few reproductive health policies, and arguably few health policies more generally, change with the frequency and polarity as laws related to abortion. By one measure, over the last 30 years there have been 64 national-level reforms to the rights that govern individual access to abortion,

Printed from Oxford Research Encyclopedias, Economics and Finance. Under the terms of the licence agreement, an individual user may print out a single article for personal use (for details see Privacy Policy and Legal Notice).
Subscriber: OUP-Reference Gratis Access; date: 20 June 2024

corresponding to around two reform changes per year (Center for Reproductive Rights, 2023). What is more, these reforms cover quite similar ground and move in both directions, at times liberalizing and at times rolling back access to abortion. The current state of abortion legislation worldwide suggests substantial differences in access across countries and by continent, as documented in Figure 1. While the broad current over the past 3 decades has been in progressively increasing access to abortion when considering national-level legislative changes, there have similarly been movements to restrict access. These reforms have received substantial attention in both the academic literature and the popular press.

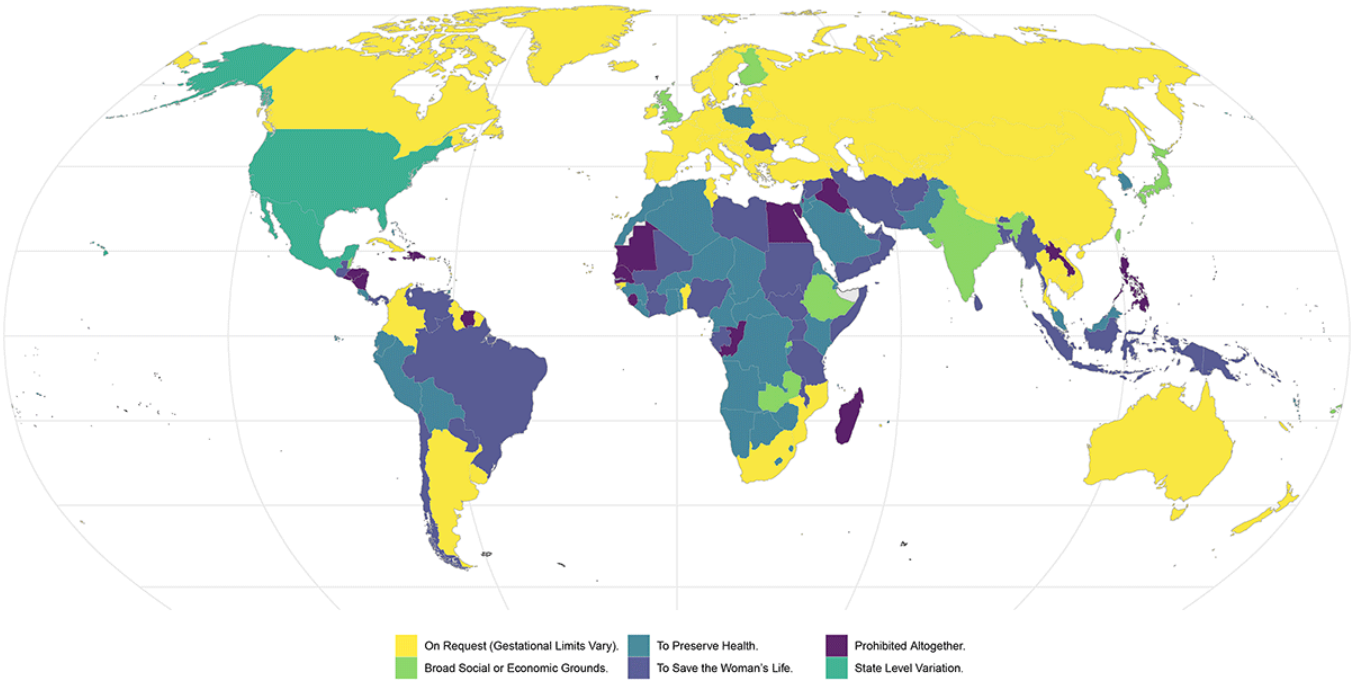


Figure 1. Exposure to national-level abortion laws (2023). Classifications of abortion legality are compiled by country and these figures refer to laws as of June 2022.

Source: Figure created by the author based on 2023 data from the Centre for Reproductive Rights

The considerable attention paid to these policies is warranted given the far-reaching impacts which abortion policy has on the lives of affected individuals. When women and families can optimally plan their desired number of children, the timing of these births, and, potentially, the spacing between births, this allows them to balance their own desires for economic security and career advancement, as well as optimally plan investment in any intended children. And when children are intended, the environments in which they live, the types of care they receive, and their well-being across their entire life course is, on average, different to when they are unintended. Historical and contemporary policy decisions taken with regard to access to abortion have undeniably shaped the outcomes of generations of women, families, and children.

This article seeks to provide a broad overview of the economics of abortion policy. The economic literature on abortion offers a number of important lessons. Abortion reform is both a highly relevant input to many factors of central importance to economists including individual well-

Printed from Oxford Research Encyclopedias, Economics and Finance. Under the terms of the licence agreement, an individual user may print out a single article for personal use (for details see Privacy Policy and Legal Notice).
Subscriber: OUP-Reference Gratis Access; date: 20 June 2024

being, human capital accumulation, demographic structures, and labor force participation. Abortion policy is itself also shaped by economic factors (Blank et al., 1996; Gonzalez & Quast, 2022), suggesting that economic research on abortion can aid in understanding both how abortion policy is set as well as how it shapes micro- and macro-level outcomes. The relevance of questions related to abortion and abortion reform in economics is reflected in its coverage in the economic literature. The quantity of papers published across economic journals suggests that understanding the impacts of abortion on individuals, families, and population cohorts is a question of general interest as well as of particular interest to fields including demographic economics, labor economics, health economics, development economics, gender economics, and law and economics.

This review is structured to first seek to synthesize how economic research shapes understanding of the passage of abortion policy as well as what can be learned from studying abortion reforms. It then covers substantive questions related to the impacts of abortion policy on individual outcomes and well-being. Specifically, it covers three key themes in this regard: understanding how abortion policy shapes abortion access, understanding how abortion policy shapes the outcomes of women and families during their fertile years, and understanding how abortion policy shapes the composition of birth cohorts both at the time of reform as well as during the lives of these individuals. Finally, some discussion is provided related to how policy makers and individuals may change their behavior as a result of abortion policy decisions.

Despite the fact that the economic literature on abortion reform is large, many of the lessons which can be drawn from this research flow from policy changes in a relatively small number of settings. This is a relevant limitation when examining the current body of knowledge from the economic literature focused on abortion policy. This is especially so when considering that many of the countries that are currently exposed to the most restrictive abortion laws—and hence potentially most likely to see shifts in their abortion laws if trends in liberalization continue—are located in high fertility environments in the developing world (of course, lack of abortion access and high fertility rates may be in part related). The majority of the papers in economics relating to abortion focus on relatively lower fertility environments, often in industrialized countries.

Nevertheless, the economic literature on abortion policy offers relevant findings when considering both the effects of liberalizing abortion policy as well as the effects of criminalization. Despite the well-documented fact that policy changes occurring since the latter half of the 20th century have been broadly progressive in nature, it may be surprising to note that the total world population living in countries with abortion available upon request is actually falling, given varying population growth rates worldwide.Figure 2 plots these trends which show that in 1994 around 30% of countries allowed abortion upon request, while in 2022 this proportion has grown to around 40% of countries. However, due to differential population growth rates, in 1994 around 45% of the world lived in a country where abortion was available upon request, while in 2022 this figure stood at closer to 30%. These broad trends, combined with the frequency of changes in abortion policy, make clear the relevance of understanding how abortion policy decisions are made and what these decisions imply for individual well-being for populations exposed to a range of policy regimes.

Printed from Oxford Research Encyclopedias, Economics and Finance. Under the terms of the licence agreement, an individual user may print out a single article for personal use (for details see Privacy Policy and Legal Notice).
Subscriber: OUP-Reference Gratis Access; date: 20 June 2024

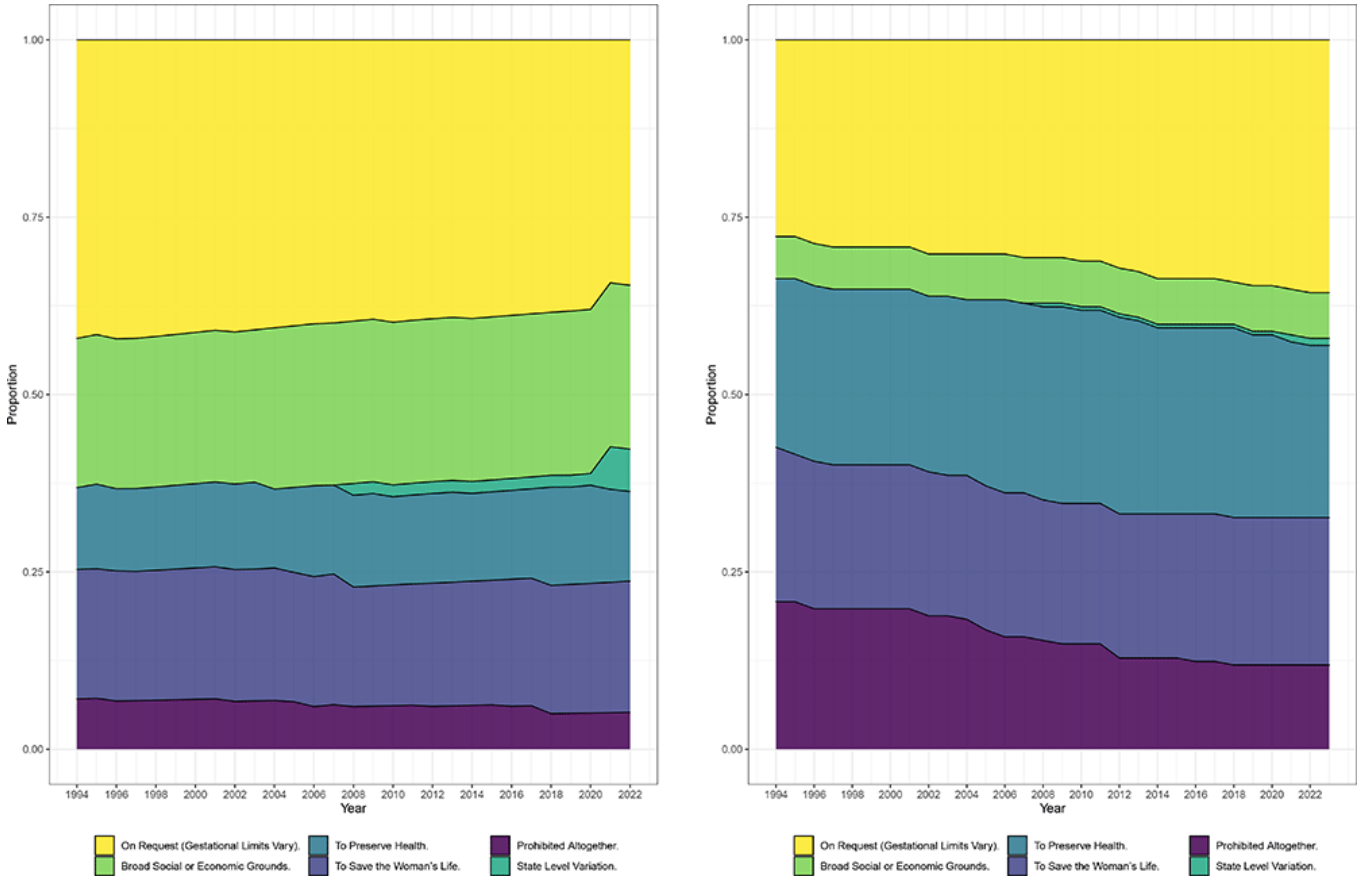


Figure 2. Changes in exposure to national-level abortion laws (1994–2023). Figures present the proportion of countries classified as being subject to alternative policy regimes (left panel) and the proportion of individuals worldwide classified as being subject to these policy regimes (right panel). Figures are plotted based on the legal classification provided by Center for Reproductive Rights (2023).

Source: Figure created by the author based on 2023 data from the Centre for Reproductive Rights

This review covers both early and subsequent literature in the economics of abortion policy, laying out the broad scope of questions studied and key points of agreement and divergence. A number of additional texts provide overviews on the economics of abortion and are likely to be of relevance to interested scholars. This includes a book by Levine (2004), which comprehensively covers the literature up to 2004 with a focus on abortion reform and its impacts on abortion access and fertility, a scoping review by van der Meulen Rodgers et al. (2021) with a particular interest in the abortion reform and macroeconomic outcomes, a review by Bernstein and Jones (2019) focused on abortion access and microlevel economic outcomes, and a handbook chapter by Joyce (2010) particularly focused on the line of research seeking to delineate links between abortion and crime. The remaining sections of this article aim to cut across themes, providing an overview of the state of the art of economic research as well as discussing implications for where the literature may go from here.

Printed from Oxford Research Encyclopedias, Economics and Finance. Under the terms of the licence agreement, an individual user may print out a single article for personal use (for details see Privacy Policy and Legal Notice).
Subscriber: OUP-Reference Gratis Access; date: 20 June 2024

What Precipitates Abortion Reforms?

What can explain the policy landscape with regard to abortion access, and what precipitates changes in abortion policy? The economic literature on abortion reform has pointed to a number of determinants of *policy change*, though in general, the complexity of abortion legislation and the way in which legal reform occurs depends on a country's specific institutions including legal origins, cultural norms, political systems, and the interaction between lawmakers and the judiciary. Nevertheless, studies which focus particularly on determinants of abortion policies have pointed to important direct and proximate factors that precipitate voting and eventual legal reform.

Political Determinants and Politician Identity

Given that legal reform is, in many cases, an overwhelmingly political process, much of the literature focuses on political determinants. Indeed, the political identity and personal circumstance of politicians have been documented to affect both voting on laws related to abortion as well as de facto access to abortion. Unsurprisingly, voting for abortion law is strongly polarized across political party lines. For example, Bouton et al. (2021) documented that in the United States of America, democratic senators are much more likely to vote in favor of prochoice positions on senate roll-call votes, while republican senators are less likely to support such positions in a sample of senate votes between 1997 and 2012.

However, beyond party affiliation, individual politician identity has also been shown to affect voting behavior. An influential paper by Washington (2008) documented that U.S. congresspeople with daughters are substantially more likely to vote liberally than those with sons. This holds particularly with votes related to abortion and reproductive health. Using voting records from the members of four houses of U.S. Congress (all houses between 1997 and 2004), Washington estimated, for example, that having an additional daughter makes a congressperson 3.5 percentage points (hereafter pp) and 3.2 pp more likely to vote in favor of prochoice positions on laws considering an abortion ban and teen access to abortion (respectively), with this particularly the case for fathers.[1] Van Effenterre (2020), considering voting patterns in both France and the United States, found that these results are heterogeneous by country and party of politicians. In the case of France, she examined the decriminalization of abortion with the passage of the "Loi Veil (Veil Act)" in 1974,[2] finding that for a right wing politician, having an additional daughter made them less likely to vote in favor of the law, while for a left wing politician, no precisely estimated impact of a daughter was observed. However, in the United States, she found that left wing politicians were substantially more likely to vote for a prochoice stance in a law regarding teenage access to abortion for each additional daughter, while no such result was observed for right wing politicians. Bhalotra et al. (2021) noted that a politician's religious identity can shape de facto rates of sex-selective abortion in India. The authors documented in a sample of close elections that increasing the proportion of Muslim state legislators rather than Hindu legislators resulted in declines in use of sex-selective abortion, in line with greater aversion to abortion among Muslims rather than Hindus. Finally, politician gender has been documented as an

Printed from Oxford Research Encyclopedias, Economics and Finance. Under the terms of the licence agreement, an individual user may print out a single article for personal use (for details see Privacy Policy and Legal Notice).
Subscriber: OUP-Reference Gratis Access; date: 20 June 2024

important determinant in voting patterns in certain contexts. For example, Washington (2008) documented that women politicians were much more likely to vote in favor of prochoice positions, although Bhalotra et al. (2023), studying the passage of parliamentary gender quotas worldwide, did not observe that reserving seats in parliament (and subsequent increases in female legislators) resulted in reform to abortion laws in the 10 subsequent years.

While the evidence discussed so far in this section all refers to the impact of national politics on the passage of abortion reform, it is worth noting that international policy may also shape access to abortion. The Global Gag Rule, or Mexico City policy, is a U.S. foreign policy that since 1984 has been invoked by republican presidents and repealed by their democratic counterparts. This policy directly limits how overseas nongovernmental organizations (NGOs) can conduct reproductive health programs (van der Meulen Rodgers, 2018), and this has been shown to have substantial effects on access to contraceptives as well as downstream outcomes in low-income countries (Jones, 2015).

Economic and Other Determinants

While much of the literature studying inputs to abortion policy and legislation is focused on political determinants, Elías et al. (2017) suggested that economic development may be a relevant determinant of the passage of more liberal abortion policy. Elías et al. (2017) additionally noted that democratic regimes and greater rights for women are associated with passage of more liberal abortion policy as well as finding that certain legal origins (specifically socialist legal origins) are associated with more permissive abortion policy. Descriptive evidence from Medoff (2002) also suggests that interest groups and characteristics of constituents are relevant correlates of the severity of abortion restrictions in the United States. They found, for example, that state-level restrictions are less severe in states with a greater presence of the National Abortion Rights Action League and more severe in states where a greater proportion of the population is Roman Catholic. While not being relevant for abortion reform but rather directly relevant for de facto access to abortion in a setting where abortion is legally available, Jacobson and Royer (2011) showed that extremist activities may curb access of women seeking abortion. They found that acts of domestic terrorism in which violence is exercised against abortion providers or at abortion clinics both reduces provider availability which limits access to abortion, and geographically shifts patterns of access.

Context Dependence in Abortion Policy

Despite these precedents from certain settings, the nature of abortion policy reform is highly context-specific. To see this, consider two emblematic examples studied in the abortion literature in economics: the first in the many policy changes in the United States of America from the 1970s to the 2020s, and in the second case of Romania in the 20th century (Mitrut & Wolff, 2011; Pop-Eleches, 2006, 2010). In the United States, abortion policy is dictated by the interpretation of the Constitution, which depends on how the Supreme Court parses relevant

Printed from Oxford Research Encyclopedias, Economics and Finance. Under the terms of the licence agreement, an individual user may print out a single article for personal use (for details see Privacy Policy and Legal Notice).
Subscriber: OUP-Reference Gratis Access; date: 20 June 2024

passages of the Constitution at the federal level, and in many state-level laws, which can eventually be referred to the Supreme Court if their validity is questioned. According to Myers's work on the history of the last 60 years of contraceptive reform in the United States:

> State policies governing young women's legal and confidential access to abortion and prescription contraception have evolved for six decades, determined by a complex and varying interplay of U.S. Supreme Court rulings and state regulations.
>
> Myers (2022, p. 1437)

What is more, this complex interplay between the Supreme Court and states at times has been led far more by states and at other times by the Supreme Court. In practice, this has meant many disparate changes, such as: the imposition and repeal of parental involvement laws, mandatory waiting periods, the closure of clinics due to requirements that physicians have admitting privileges at hospitals, and sharp changes in gestational week limits given the passage of state-level laws. It has also meant large sharp changes such as the nationwide legalization of abortion given the Supreme Court's decision in *Roe v. Wade* in 1973. However, this complex interplay between politicians and the judiciary is not always observed. In 1966 the Romanian government of Ceauşescu, the Romanian dictator, imposed Constitutional Decree 770, which immediately banned abortion and contraception except in specific and very limiting circumstances. This near total ban remained in place until the Romanian Revolution in December 1989 and the fall of Ceauşescu, at which point the new government legalized abortion on January 1, 1990, on only their fifth day in power. Thus, while the economic literature points to specific factors which are inputs to abortion policy in particular contexts, the vast differences in experiences of abortion reform across countries illustrated in these two particular cases suggests that the evidence must be viewed through this lens.

What Can Be Learned From Studying Abortion Reforms?

Identifying Variation

The majority of empirical studies in economics seeking to estimate the impact of abortion availability draws identification from legal reforms. There are certain exceptions, such as evidence from the Turnaway Study (Miller et al., 2020, 2023) discussed in section "How Does Abortion Reform Shape the Outcomes of Affected Cohorts of Women?" of this article, but overwhelmingly, evidence is driven by natural experiments based on policy or legal reform. The specific characteristics of these natural experiments have key implications for what can be learned about abortion reform. Reforms may work at different margins (e.g., limiting or liberalizing access), may deal with particular restrictions (e.g., changing access to abortion in particular circumstances), may work with particular age groups, and are naturally context-dependent, both in terms of the time period studied as well as the particular country, countries,

Printed from Oxford Research Encyclopedias, Economics and Finance. Under the terms of the licence agreement, an individual user may print out a single article for personal use (for details see Privacy Policy and Legal Notice).
Subscriber: OUP-Reference Gratis Access; date: 20 June 2024

or regions considered. These are points of *external validity*, and in the section "The Nature of Abortion Reforms Studied" these are enumerated at length, with a discussion of the types of settingsin which the literature is informative.

Questions of external validity relate not just to potential differences between two countries or regions under study but more generally to the wider environment in which a policy reform takes place. In the case of abortion reforms, a particularly relevant consideration related to external validity is the degree to which access to abortion exists in the absence of any formal legal policy. In the absence of legalized abortion, induced abortion is still widely used but simply shifts to extralegal and unsafe conditions (Sedgh et al., 2012). The degree to which legal abortion is substituted by extralegal abortion will depend on the safety of alternative procedures. This is a relevant point given evidence of growing availability of relatively safe pharmaceutical options for self-managed abortion.[3] In particular, since the 1980s there has been growing awareness of abortifacient properties of drugs which were often available over the counter, such as misoprostol (refer, e.g., to Calkin, 2023). Along with informal networks, there are also organizations such as Women on Waves which distribute such drugs in settings where access to abortion is restricted. The impact of the growing availability of such drugs on the bite of abortion laws is an open question but suggests that effects from historical restrictions on abortion may be different to abortion restrictions after more widespread availability of self-managed medical abortion.

Additionally, the suitability of using policy reform to understand the impacts of abortion on individual outcomes presumes *internal validity*. When estimating the impact of abortion availability or restrictions for a particular group exposed to some policy reform, it is necessary to estimate an unbiased counterfactual for what would have happened to this group in the state of the world in which such a reform had not been passed. Assuming that such a counterfactual can be estimated, an average treatment effect on the treated (ATT) can be generated. This is challenging, as discussed, for example, by Joyce (2013) who noted that at a minimum if one wishes to learn lessons about the impact of abortion access from abortion reform, a number of conditions are required. In particular, (a) the reform must actually affect access to abortion; (b) the reform may not affect other relevant factors apart from abortion; (c) the assignment mechanism which results in certain populations being affected by the reform but others not affected must be understood; and (d) a causal channel must exist allowing for downstream results to be considered. This is also a point made clear by Besley and Case (2000). They noted that policies are naturally endogenous decisions, and understanding the impact of any policy change requires separating the effect of the reform from any underlying processes that may have propelled the reform to occur, and at the same time be related to outcomes of interest. Particularly in the case of abortion, states that impose more draconian abortion reforms may be generally engaging in policies which limit the rights of women and vice versa in times of liberalizing policy. In general, plausibly estimating the effect of abortion policy on outcomes of interest requires separating the specific effect of abortion reform from any suite of policy decisions. Typically, the empirical studies discussed in this article spend considerable time laying out the requirements for internal validity, and the identification strategy will be a key element of

Printed from Oxford Research Encyclopedias, Economics and Finance. Under the terms of the licence agreement, an individual user may print out a single article for personal use (for details see Privacy Policy and Legal Notice).
Subscriber: OUP-Reference Gratis Access; date: 20 June 2024

any such study. As discussed in the section "Abortion, Child Circumstances, and Crime," discussions of identification strategies themselves have spurred substantial strands of literature in work on the impacts of abortion policy.

Finally, it is worth noting that where within-country variation in abortion access is used to identify the impact of abortion policy on outcomes of interest, and where reforms of interest occurred long in the past, measurement of reform is not necessarily trivial. While in certain cases law changes are unambiguous (based on widely documented political events, e.g., Pop-Eleches, 2006, 2010 or policy reforms, e.g., Brooks & Zohar, 2021; Clarke & Mühlrad, 2021), in other cases, multiple state-level reforms and contradictory legislative findings may mean that the exact dating of reforms is not straightforward and requires substantial archival work. The importance of measurement as well as documentation that measurement errors may exist in the literature was discussed by Myers (2022), who additionally proposed a clear coding for U.S. state-level reform in the 1960s and 1970s.

The Nature of Abortion Reforms Studied

Liberalizations or Restrictions

Likely the most salient element of abortion reform is the whether the reform acts to restrict or liberalize access to abortion, and its results are generally clear. For example, the passage of *Roe v. Wade* in 1973 codified access to abortion in the United States nationwide, implying that the reform was liberal in nature. Similarly, Mølland (2016) studied a reform of abortion law in Norway in which access was liberalized for teenagers 4 years earlier in Oslo than in the rest of the country. A particularly interesting case is that of Romania, where abortion was widely accessed before being immediately criminalized in 1966 and then legalized once again 34 years later in 1990. This reform has been influential in studies in economics given that it has provided two sharp changes with considerable pre- and post-study periods available (see e.g., Hjalmarsson et al., 2021; Mitrut & Wolff, 2011; Pop-Eleches, 2006, 2010), all of which study one or both of these particular legal shifts.

Other clear examples of liberalizations studied in the economic literature on abortion include Canada (Sen, 2007), the United States (Myers, 2017, inter alia), and England and Wales (Kahane et al., 2008) during the period of the 1960s and 1970s, and later liberalizations such as Spain and Taiwan in the 1980s (González et al., 2018; Lin et al., 2014), a number of Eastern European countries in the 1980s and 1990s (Levine & Staiger, 2004), Nepal in the early 2000s (Valente, 2014), Mexico in 2007 (Clarke & Mühlrad, 2021), and Uruguay in 2012 (Antón et al., 2018). Examples of restrictions have been studied in a broad range of time periods, including antiabortion laws in the United States in the 1850s–1910s (Lahey, 2014a, 2014b), the Romanian policy shift of 1966, late 20th and early 21st century state-level restrictions limiting both provision of abortion (e.g., Arnold, 2022) and individual access to abortion in the United States (e.g., Lindo & Pineda-Torres, 2021), as well as certain state-level legal tightening in Mexico examined in Clarke and Mühlrad (2021). A small number of studies also exist discussing the

Printed from Oxford Research Encyclopedias, Economics and Finance. Under the terms of the licence agreement, an individual user may print out a single article for personal use (for details see Privacy Policy and Legal Notice).
Subscriber: OUP-Reference Gratis Access; date: 20 June 2024

impacts of restrictions in the United States flowing from the Supreme Court's 2022 decision in *Dobbs v. Jackson Women's Health Organization*, which devolved decisions related to abortion access back to states (Dench et al., 2023; Myers, 2023).

Causes

Abortion reform may impose or remove limits. In certain settings, abortion may be allowed in particular circumstances such as in cases of risk to the mother's life or health, in cases of fetal inviability, or in cases of rape, but not broadly upon request. Thus, reforms may move particular margins of these restrictions or eliminate restrictions all together. This includes cases such as the passage of *Roe v. Wade* in the United States, which codified access to abortion upon request nationwide, similarly to abortion reform studied in Mexico, Uruguay, and Norway (among others). In other cases, abortion reform may be more moderate, for example, the case of abortion reform in Spain in 1985 and the United Kingdom in 1967 where abortion was not available upon request but was available in the other three specific clauses of health, fetal inviability, or rape (González et al., 2018; Kahane et al., 2008).

However, it is important to note that both the causes and the interpretation of the causes may vary substantially. An interesting case in point is the abortion liberalization in both Spain and in the United Kingdom, which, while nominally putting limits on access to abortion, in a de facto sense did not imply substantial limits, given that in both settings the maternal health criterion was widely used to include mental health concerns. In other settings, the interpretation of abortion restrictions may also vary, with quite different implementations of criminal sanctions imposed in settings where abortion was illegal; see, for example, the case of Mexican states studied in Clarke and Mühlrad (2021) or draconian measures to ensure compliance with the law in Pop-Eleches (2006), compared with state-level policy reform in the United States, where it has been well documented that individuals with means to travel over state lines can access abortion in states with less strict policies (Dench et al., 2023; Fischer et al., 2018; Joyce & Kaestner, 2001; Lindo et al., 2020a; Myers, 2023; Venator & Fletcher, 2020).

Types of Restrictions

The nature of reforms varies considerably by countries and time periods. These include outright legalizations (e.g., Antón et al., 2018; Myers, 2017; Sen, 2007) or criminalization (e.g., Lahey, 2014b; Pop-Eleches, 2006) but additionally include restrictions that are more piecemeal, making access harder by either reducing access to abortion at the supply side (providers) or demand side (individuals).

Examples of demand-side policies include funding reforms such as restrictions that limit the coverage of abortion from public funds; see, for example, Blank et al. (1996) for discussion of U.S. Medicaid funding restrictions or Brooks and Zohar (2021), who considered the converse setting where reforms occur to increase the provision of free access to abortion without changing any underlying restrictions. Similarly, other restrictions on the demand side include the passage of laws which impose mandatory minimum waiting periods and require women to receive

Printed from Oxford Research Encyclopedias, Economics and Finance. Under the terms of the licence agreement, an individual user may print out a single article for personal use (for details see Privacy Policy and Legal Notice).
Subscriber: OUP-Reference Gratis Access; date: 20 June 2024

information about abortion procedures and then wait some prestipulated amount of time before being able to access the procedure (see, e.g., Altındağ & Joyce, 2022; Lindo & Pineda-Torres, 2021). More invasive laws in a similar vein have been studied; for example, Gius (2019) considered laws requiring ultrasounds prior to abortions being performed. Additional examples include the passage of parental involvement laws requiring parents of women under 18 years of age to be informed or otherwise provide consent prior to an abortion being provided (Joyce & Kaestner, 2001). A number of papers, for example Bitler and Zavodny (2004), considered multiple such restrictions in a single setting.

Examples of supply-side policies include laws that impose restrictions on providers such as hospital admitting privileges or requirements to meet specific medical, infrastructure, or other licensing criteria. These laws, known in the United States as TRAP laws (for Targeted Regulation of Abortion Providers) have been widely studied in this setting, given the proliferation of such policies across U.S. states since the 1990s (Arnold, 2022; Crowe et al., 2023; Fischer et al., 2018; Gardner, 2022; Jones & Pineda-Torres, 2021; Lindo et al., 2020a; Muratori, 2021). A description of the full nature of these laws can be found in Jones and Pineda-Torres (2021). Further detail is provided on the nature of these reforms as well as their implications in the section entitled "Evidence on the Nature and Magnitude of Effects of Abortion Reform" in this review.

Age Limits

Policies may inherently target specific age groups, and in cases such as these, any findings will naturally be limited to the age groups affected by policies. Along with parental involvement laws which affect women under the ages of 18, certain policies only affect other specific age groups such as a roll-out of free abortion provision in Israel to 20–32-year-olds (Brooks & Zohar, 2021) or abortion restrictions that were put in place in Romania for all women, with exceptions for women above certain age cutoffs (Pop-Eleches, 2006). Even within the country studied in such settings, results will provide lessons for the particular population groups which are affected by marginal reform changes, and as such, external validity to other groups *within the same country* cannot be assumed.

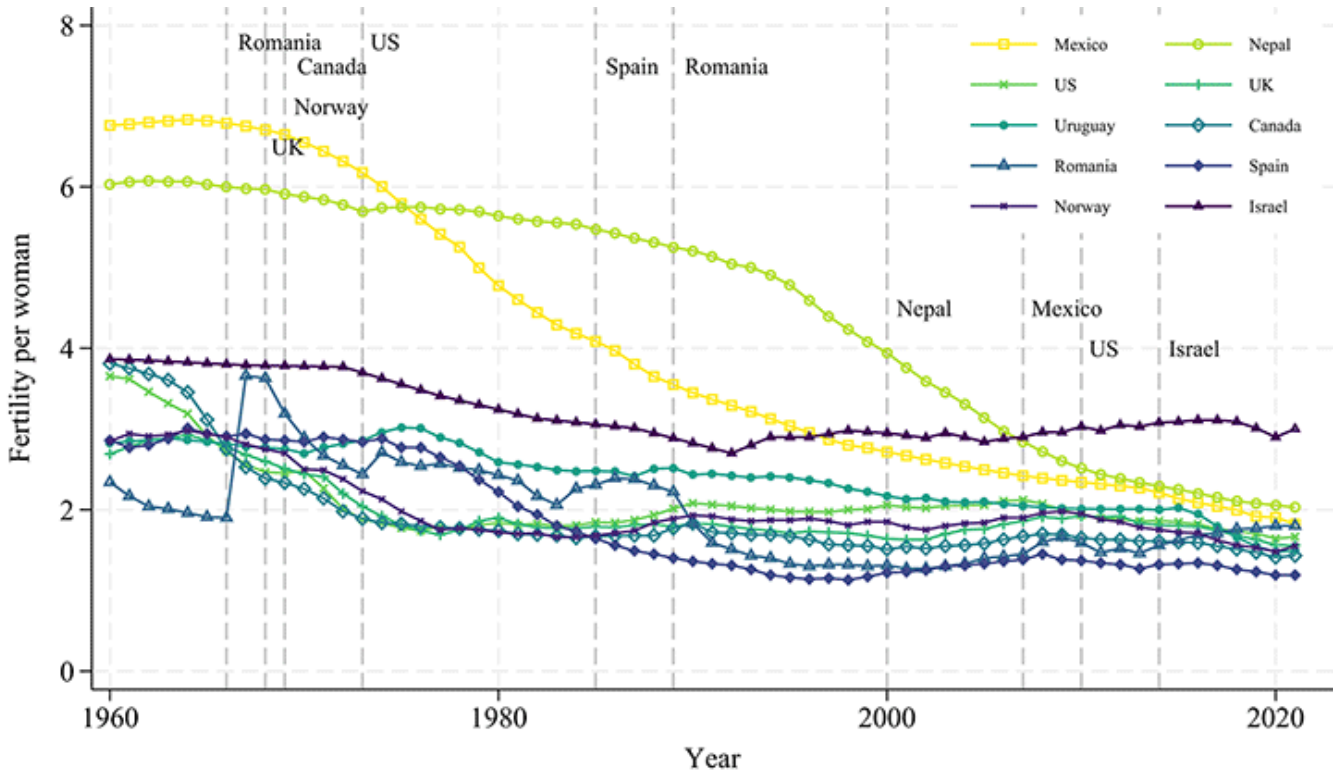
Limits to the Current Knowledge of Abortion Reform in Economics

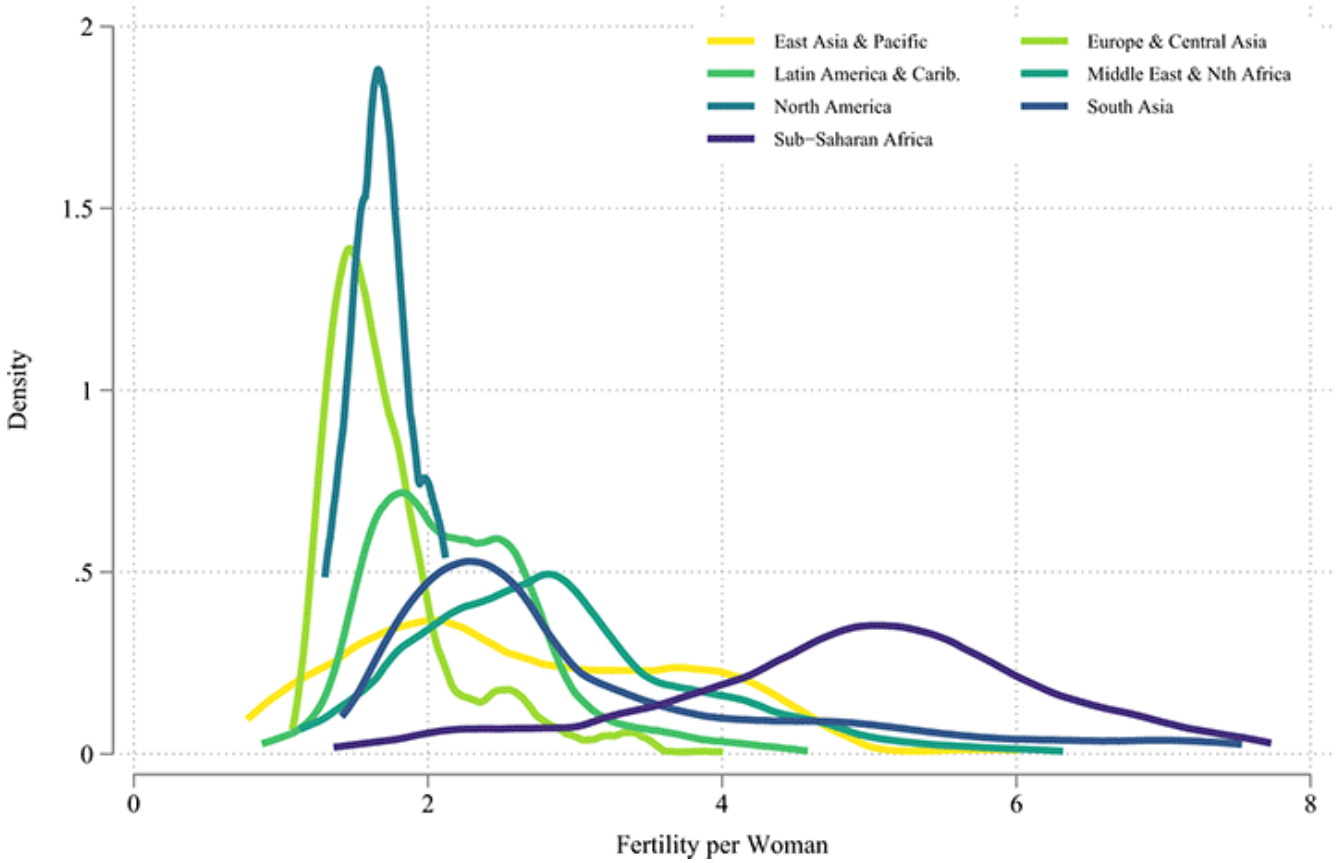
More generally, it is important to note that the external validity of the reasonably large literature on abortion reform in economics may be limited. While quite a large number of papers on abortion have been published in the economic literature, the number of settings studied has been quite selective, in large part owing to the availability of suitable national-level reforms to study and/or the availability of data. Indeed, a majority of the papers in the literature are from a single country—the United States—though from a number of policy reforms. While these papers provide a large body of evidence to understand the impacts of abortion reform in the United States from the 1970s and beyond, they may provide limited evidence on the implications for abortion reform in other settings.

Printed from Oxford Research Encyclopedias, Economics and Finance. Under the terms of the licence agreement, an individual user may print out a single article for personal use (for details see Privacy Policy and Legal Notice).
Subscriber: OUP-Reference Gratis Access; date: 20 June 2024

Throughout this article, abortion reforms are discussed which have been studied in papers published in academic journals in economics.[4] Figure 3a provides a plot covering the period of 1960–2021 indicating the dates when studied reforms took place (dashed grey lines) as well as the fertility rates of the countries in which reforms were studied. Despite the fact that these reforms occurred over a substantial period of time, virtually all reforms occurred in relatively low fertility environments. Indeed, the majority of reforms studied occurred in countries and time periods in which fertility was close to the replacement rate (around two births per woman over her lifetime), though historical reforms such as those in the 1960s and 1970s in the United States occurred in higher fertility environments, at closer to three births per woman. One exception to this is the reform studied by Brooks and Zohar (2021) in Israel in 2014, where the total fertility rate was slightly higher than three births per woman over her lifetime; however, this reform is a financial shift where abortion was permitted both pre- and post-reform.

Printed from Oxford Research Encyclopedias, Economics and Finance. Under the terms of the licence agreement, an individual user may print out a single article for personal use (for details see Privacy Policy and Legal Notice).
Subscriber: OUP-Reference Gratis Access; date: 20 June 2024





Printed from Oxford Research Encyclopedias, Economics and Finance. Under the terms of the licence agreement, an individual user may print out a single article for personal use (for details see Privacy Policy and Legal Notice).
Subscriber: OUP-Reference Gratis Access; date: 20 June 2024

Figure 3. Studied abortion reforms and fertility levels. Reform dates in the top panel refer to reforms discussed in this article, though at times refer to ranges of reform dates (such as state-level legal reforms in the United States that occurred over a wide period though are signaled in 2010 in the plot. Fertility distributions in the bottom panel are plotted for all countries in each region for years 2000–2020 only to provide a more recent snapshot of fertility levels pooling all country by year observations.

Source: Dates of abortion reforms are compiled by the author. Fertility data is compiled in the World Bank Databank

When comparing fertility rates in these reform contexts to fertility rates worldwide (Figure 3b), it seems that these may provide limited lessons in certain contexts. This figure provides density plots of country fertility rates over years 2000–2020 by world region, where a substantial portion of countries had fertility rates well in excess of those in reform countries, especially in Sub-Saharan Africa, though average fertility is well above two births per woman in all regions except North America, Europe, and Central Asia. When considering that the vast majority of countries that could conceivably liberalize abortion laws are located outside of North America, Europe, and Central Asia, lessons from the reforms studied in the economic literature may be limited in terms of their predictive power for the impact of any reforms in these settings, at least if impacts depend on baseline fertility rates.

Evidence on the Nature and Magnitude of Effects of Abortion Reform

Abortion Reform and Abortion Access

A precursor to considering any impacts of abortion policy on outcomes of women and families is to understand how these policies affect access to abortion in the first instance. Such "first stage" policy impacts are necessary for these policy changes to have any downstream effects (Joyce, 2013). Being able to convincingly document reform impacts on rates of abortion is, at times, challenging, as in many contexts, the policy reform implies that elective abortion is illegal in either the prepolicy or postpolicy period. In cases where abortion is illegal, measuring rates of abortion is very difficult,[5] and even in cases where abortion is legal, many of the reforms studied in the economic literature on abortion occurred a significant time in the past, for example in the 1970s, implying that access to data on abortion rates can be challenging (Blank et al., 1996).

Nevertheless, a range of papers have provided credible estimates of the impact of both historical and more recent abortion reforms on actual rates of abortion. In general, these studies leverage identifying variation from differences in access across geographic areas within countries over time (e.g., state-level or even county-level variation in the United States); however, in certain settings even time-series variation provides credible information on the impact of abortion laws on rates of abortion. Much of the evidence based on the impact of abortion policy on abortion rates comes from the United States covering the period from the late 1970s to the 2020s. This is a period in which U.S. states were emboldened to enact their own laws related to abortion access as a result of a number of political events and legal findings; in particular, the adoption of the Hyde Amendment in 1980, which restricts the use of federal funds such as Medicaid to finance

Printed from Oxford Research Encyclopedias, Economics and Finance. Under the terms of the licence agreement, an individual user may print out a single article for personal use (for details see Privacy Policy and Legal Notice).
Subscriber: OUP-Reference Gratis Access; date: 20 June 2024

abortion, as well as the Supreme Court decision in *Planned Parenthood v. Casey* in 1992, which allowed states to impose restrictions on access to abortion provided that those restrictions did not result in an "undue burden" on a woman's access to abortion before a fetus became viable. Studies from the United States thus have examined the impact of reforms such as Medicaid funding changes; laws which seek to restrict individual access to abortion, including parental involvement laws and waiting periods; and laws which seek to restrict providers' ability to offer abortion, such as the need for clinics to have admitting privileges in hospitals.

Among studies to consider the impact of cuts to Medicaid funding on rates of abortion Blank et al. (1996) and Levine et al. (1996) provided early evidence of the relevance of changes in funding on abortion rates. Using data on abortion rates collected by the Guttmacher Institute, Levine et al. (1996) found that funding restrictions reduced rates of abortion by 5.5% among women aged 15–44. Blank et al. (1996) also examined the effect of funding on abortion rates, additionally considering data on abortion rates from the Center for Disease Control. The results of Blank et al. (1996) show not only declines of a similar magnitude to those in Levine et al. (1996) but also the existence of cross-state effects. They suggested these cross-state effects were due to declines in rates of individuals traveling across state lines to access abortion. Blank et al. (1996) found that the total effect of funding restrictions may be as high as 13% if including both in-state and cross-state effects and additionally noted that these effects are much higher among Medicaid eligible women— between 19%–25%. While Medicaid funding cuts were imposed at the federal level, certain states made funds available at the state level to cover abortion for women on Medicaid. Cook et al. (1999) used a particular situation in North Carolina where state-level abortion funds ran out before the end of a number of financial years, and estimate that for affected women, around one third of abortions which would have been performed were actually taken to term given the lack of funding availability. Taken together, these findings suggest that the availability of financing is a highly relevant element in access to abortion.

The impact of laws that restrict access has also been documented in considering parental involvement laws for young women. Such laws, which were passed in a reasonably large proportion of U.S. states from the late 1970s onward and require that parents are notified when women under 18 seek an abortion, have been found to have substantial impacts on abortion rates for young women. Haas-Wilson (1996) found that the laws decreased rates of abortion by between 13% and 25%, with Levine (2003) finding broadly similar effects. Bitler and Zavodny (2001) additionally noted that declines in access to abortion owing to these laws resulted in increased rates of later-gestational abortion, with implications for the health and well-being of women. More recent analyses based on event study models (Joyce et al., 2020) suggest the impacts of such laws may be limited to earlier time periods (pre-1990), while Joyce and Kaestner (2001) noted that minors may travel out of state to blunt the impact of such reforms. A further review of these laws as well as discussions related to data quality are provided by Dennis et al. (2009), and Myers and Ladd (2020) provided considerable further discussion related to challenges in measuring abortion rates, suggesting that these estimates should be viewed with caution. Nevertheless, Myers and Ladd (2020) documented that parental involvement laws *do* increase births, which they noted are not subject to the same measurement error problems as abortions.

Printed from Oxford Research Encyclopedias, Economics and Finance. Under the terms of the licence agreement, an individual user may print out a single article for personal use (for details see Privacy Policy and Legal Notice).
Subscriber: OUP-Reference Gratis Access; date: 20 June 2024

A final set of demand-side laws considered are the imposition of mandatory waiting periods. Mandatory delay laws, which can require that individuals travel twice to abortion facilities to seek an abortion, have been documented to have substantial impacts on abortion rates (Altındağ & Joyce, 2022), the proportion of abortions conducted in the second trimester (Lindo & Pineda-Torres, 2021), and, in certain contexts, an increase in the rate of out-of-state abortions (Joyce & Kaestner, 2001). Altındağ and Joyce (2022), using a regression discontinuity design and a law change in Arkansas in 2015 that required that women make two trips to abortion providers prior to accessing abortion, found that these mandatory delay laws reduced rates of abortion by 17%. While these studies suggest that these laws can be highly relevant in affecting access to abortion, earlier evidence from Bitler and Zavodny (2001) suggests that this may not always be the case. In their setting studying earlier mandatory delay laws, they found relatively little evidence on impacts of these laws on rates of abortion, potentially because unlike the laws studied in Lindo and Pineda-Torres (2021) and Altındağ and Joyce (2022), the earlier laws principally required a single trip to abortion providers. This is supported by Myers (2021) who specificallyconsidered the differential impacts of mandatory waiting periods that imply two trips versus one trip to abortion clinics. She found that while one-trip waiting period restrictions do not have substantial effects on rates of abortion or birth, in cases where two-trip requirements are imposed, this results in substantial increases in rates of abortion occurring in the second trimester, declines in abortion rates among state residents by around 9%, and increases in birth rates of around 1.5%. Such results are larger among low income and among Hispanic and Black women, while also being larger in states with longer travel times to out-of-state abortion clinics.

An alternative set of studies examined laws in the United States that seek to limit the provision of abortion from the supply side. These laws, referred to as Targeted Regulation of Abortion Providers (or TRAP laws), impose a series of restrictions on abortion providers including requiring that they meet the requirements of Ambulatory Surgical Centers (ASCs) which can be costly, especially for small clinics, or that they have admitting privileges at a nearby hospital. Such reforms have been studied by (among others) Colman and Joyce (2011) who focused on ASCs in Texas; Fischer et al. (2018), Lindo et al. (2020a), and Crowe et al. (2023) who studied Texas' HB2 law, which imposed ASC and hospital admitting privileges (including maximum distances to nearby hospitals); and Arnold (2022), Caraher (2023), Jones and Pineda-Torres (2021), Muratori (2021), and Gardner (2022) who considered state-level reforms nationwide. All told, these papers suggest that supply-side laws can have substantial effects on rates of clinic closures, the distance individuals must travel to reach their nearest clinic, and finally on rates of abortion. For example, Arnold (2022) presented convincing event-study evidence which suggests that the passage of TRAP laws reduces rates of abortion by 5% in the short run and by more than 10% in the medium run. Studies by Fischer et al. (2018), Lindo et al. (2020a), Venator and Fletcher (2020), and Myers (2023), as well as earlier work by Joyce et al. (2013) all provide convincing evidence that a relevant mechanism is the increase travel time because of clinic closures. For example, the estimates of Fischer et al. (2018) based on clinic closures in Texas showed that when a county does not have an abortion clinic within 25 miles, abortion rates fall by 16.6% compared to counties which do. Subsequent work by Caraher (2023) provided an analysis based on rich data with abortion rates at

Printed from Oxford Research Encyclopedias, Economics and Finance. Under the terms of the licence agreement, an individual user may print out a single article for personal use (for details see Privacy Policy and Legal Notice).
Subscriber: OUP-Reference Gratis Access; date: 20 June 2024

the level of the county in the United States and considered both demand-side (mandatory waiting period) and supply-side (TRAP) laws and found that supply-side laws result in larger declines in abortion rates.

While the majority of the economic literature focusing on abortion reforms and abortion access is set in the United States, Brooks and Zohar (2021) were also able to provide evidence from the expansion of free provision of elective abortion in Israel in 2014. In this setting, free provision was found to result in relatively smaller effects on abortion rates than those found based on funding cuts due to Medicaid in the United States, with the authors documenting that free provision increased rates of abortion by 4.5%–7%. It must be noted, however, that there is a socioeconomic gradient in this result, consistent with findings from Medicaid in the United States.

How Does Abortion Reform Shape the Outcomes of Affected Cohorts of Women?

Fertility and Family Formation

In line with abortion reform affecting abortion rates, there is considerable evidence in a number of settings that changes in abortion availability have important impacts on fertility, with evidence that it also affects young women's marriage decisions. Results are observed from both liberalizations in abortion policy—which have been shown to result in declines in birth rates—as well as in the implementation of abortion restrictions—which have been shown to bring about sharp increases in birth rates.

Naturally, the effect of reforms is highly context dependent. The magnitude of the effect depends upon how much *de jure* legislative change generates *de facto* policy change. For example, certain reforms are radical changes, dramatically altering the nature of access to abortion when comparing prereform to postreform circumstances. Situations of this nature include cases such as the Romanian criminalization (1966) and legalization (1990), wherein prior to 1966 abortion was widely used, and post-1966 sanctions were extremely strict and highly monitored. A similar case, though slightly less extreme was that of *Roe v. Wade* in 1973 in the United States. Prior to the reform, abortion was available in only certain early-access states (Myers, 2022) while postreform abortion was available nationwide upon request. Both reforms could be conceivably expected to generate large changes in fertility given that the reforms have substantial bite. Other reforms, in contrast, are likely to have smaller effects on fertility given that their de facto impact is lower. For example, a number of state-level legal restrictions in Mexico were considered by Clarke and Mühlrad (2021) but given that these simply increased sanctions on (already criminalized) abortion, any fertility effects are likely to be modest.

In a landmark study in the United States, Myers (2017) suggested that liberalization in abortion access during the 1970s led to large changes in rates of fertility as well as "shotgun marriages"[6] among young women. Using state-level variation in abortion availability for young women during the period of 1970–1973 and a difference-in-difference design, Myers estimated that abortion liberalization is responsible for a 3 pp (or 34%) decline in first births and 19% decline in

Printed from Oxford Research Encyclopedias, Economics and Finance. Under the terms of the licence agreement, an individual user may print out a single article for personal use (for details see Privacy Policy and Legal Notice).
Subscriber: OUP-Reference Gratis Access; date: 20 June 2024

first marriages prior to the age of 19, with even larger declines observed in shotgun marriages. These results are conditioned on the availability of the contraceptive pill, with the effects of the contraceptive pill observed to be small in comparison to those of abortion availability, particularly when abortion is available to minors without parental consent restrictions.

These effects cohere with other estimates documented from liberalizing policy changes that similarly resulted in large effective changes in abortion law. Mølland (2016) estimated that liberalizing reform in Norway in 1969 resulted in a 3 pp decline in teenage motherhood (a 16% decline), with no effect on completed fertility. Pop-Eleches (2010) found even larger effects following the Romanian liberalization of 1989: a decline in 30% in fertility rates, which *does* affect completed fertility. Liberalization in Mexico in 2007 was similarly observed to produce declines in birth rates of around 8% for all women (Clarke & Mühlrad, 2021) with similar figures observed following liberalization in Uruguay, at least among unplanned births (Antón et al., 2018). What all these reforms share is that they increase access to abortion and generate a substantial discontinuity in the nature of the policy environment moving from pre- to post-policy, in each case removing any limits (apart from gestational limits) in how abortion can be sought. It is important to note that even in cases where certain limits remain in place, liberalizations can still result in substantial declines in fertility: see, for example, the case of Spain studied in González et al. (2018), who documented a 6% decline in fertility among young women exposed to legalized abortion despite the fact that abortion was limited to three particular cases.

Such results are not limited to liberalizing abortion reforms. Indeed, generally speaking, effects of approximately the same size (or larger) but in the opposite direction are observed when abortion restrictions are put in place. One example of this in an historical setting is Lahey (2014b) who studied U.S. state-level antiabortion laws put in place between 1850–1910. Using census microdata and difference-in-differences style modeling, Lahey found that the existence of a state-level antiabortion law increased the child to woman ratio by 12%. This finding was echoed in more recent literature. When abortion was criminalized in Romania in 1966, the number of births was immediately observed to more than double, with Hjalmarsson et al. (2021) estimating an increase in the number of births by 133% following the abolition of abortion. While this context resulted in the highest change in birth rates documented in the literature, this likely owes to (a) the relative frequency of abortion at baseline in Romania; (b) the strict nature of the ban and its enforcement; and (c) the fact that use of clandestine abortion only grew in later years, rather than at the (surprise) announcement of the legal reform.

A number of papers have documented how impacts on fertility occur over the life cycle. A key question in this setting is whether any impacts of abortion reform on fertility are *transitory*, simply allowing individuals to time the births they would like to have in a more optimal way, or *permanent*, implying that the availability of abortion results in fewer births on average when individuals reach the end of their childbearing years. Ananat et al. (2007), studying the case of early legal access in the United States in the 1970s, found that in this setting, fertility declines were permanent: women not giving birth as a result of increased abortion availability in this period did not tend to go on to increase births later in life. What is more, they found that much of this result was due to women being more likely to remain childless. A similar effect from abortion

Printed from Oxford Research Encyclopedias, Economics and Finance. Under the terms of the licence agreement, an individual user may print out a single article for personal use (for details see Privacy Policy and Legal Notice).
Subscriber: OUP-Reference Gratis Access; date: 20 June 2024

restrictions was observed in Romania, with Pop-Eleches (2010) documenting that women who spent much of their fertile life under periods with sharp limits on abortion access had higher life cycle fertility than later cohorts after abortion bans were lifted. However, these results are not observed in all contexts. Both Mølland (2016) and González et al. (2018) found that while liberalizing abortion reforms in Norway and Spain, respectively, resulted in declines in fertility early in life, these were transitory rather than permanent, principally affecting timing rather than total fertility.

While in many contexts the impact of abortion reform on fertility is clear, in other cases impacts are less so. One such example are parental involvement laws in the United States, where the literature suggests divergent results. Early work from Kane and Staiger (1996) and Levine (2003) suggests that there is relatively little evidence that these laws have aggregate effects on teen fertility, though subsequent work has suggested that the bite of these laws has increased, with significant increases in fertility observed with the passage of laws (Myers & Ladd, 2020). As Myers and Ladd (2020) noted, these results may be due to the broader context in which reforms take place, as the growing frequency of parental involvement laws means that the existence of nearby states that offer abortion without parental involvement is limited, unlike in earlier periods where out-of-state travel may act as an imperfect substitute for in-state access to abortion without parental involvement.

Notwithstanding some particular settings in which the fertility effects of abortion reforms may be more moderate, the general picture painted from the economic literature is that abortion availability has important impacts on birth rates, fertility timing, and at times, total fertility. This has been observed in a range of studies, covering abortion restrictions and liberalizations, a range of time periods from as early as 1850 to as late as the 2020s, and in a range of countries and continents, pointing to the enduring importance of abortion as a birth control method across space and time. There is relatively little evidence in the economic literature on abortion to suggest that abortion access is irrelevant as a fertility control mechanism, even in settings where modern contraceptives such as the pill are available.

Women's Human Capital Attainment

The impact of abortion reform on fertility has myriad longer-term impacts on women and families. Consider the legalization of abortion and the corresponding changes in timing of fertility. If women's ability to control their fertility improves, this potentially allows delays in marriage and allows women to invest more in their own human capital (Katz & Goldin, 2002). Empirical evidence of the relevance of this relationship has been documented in a number of contexts.

In 1960s Norway, Mølland (2016) substantiated this link between abortion legalization and women's education, finding that after the early passage of abortion reforms in Oslo, women were 1.8% more likely to graduate with a college degree and 0.8% more likely to gain an advanced degree. Mølland did not observe evidence of impacts on completion of high school. Educational effects were also documented by Angrist and Evans (1996) who studied U.S. state abortion reforms progressively legalizing abortion between 1967 and 1973. (Similar results are discussed

Printed from Oxford Research Encyclopedias, Economics and Finance. Under the terms of the licence agreement, an individual user may print out a single article for personal use (for details see Privacy Policy and Legal Notice).
Subscriber: OUP-Reference Gratis Access; date: 20 June 2024

by Ananat et al., 2007 though results are mixed.) They documented that these abortion reforms increased the likelihood that Black women attend college by around 3 pp, with no similar effect observed for White women (or for men). Finally, evidence from Spain presented in González et al. (2018) suggests that greater availability of abortion reduces the likelihood of high school dropouts. As in the case of fertility, in the case of education, effects are observed to be bidirectional: Pop-Eleches (2006) documented that mothers exposed to the 1966 Romanian abortion ban were 4.8 pp less likely to have primary education as their highest level of education and 4.5 pp more likely to have a secondary education. Jones and Pineda-Torres (2021) documented that abortion restrictions can be translated into declines in educational attainment quite quickly. Studying Black women in the United States, they found that TRAP laws implemented in the 1990s and 2000s resulted in declines in rates of college initiation of around 2% for women exposed to restrictions during their adolescence. All these results point in the direction of greater agency in birth timing owing to abortion liberalization being positive for human capital accumulation and reduced agency compressing educational attainment.

Labor Market Outcomes

Effects similar to those on education are observed when considering labor market participation (both at the extensive and intensive margin), salaries, and financial security. Many papers that study women's human capital accumulation also document follow-on effects on labor market outcomes. This includes Angrist and Evans (1996) who found that as with educational attainment, employment rates for Black women (but not White women) are higher by around 1.2 pp when abortion is available, though they found no evidence of impacts on log earnings. Studying these reforms, more recent work from Jones et al. (2021) found that access increases the likelihood that women work in professional or managerial roles and increases individual and family incomes, similarly observing that results are driven by Black women in the United States. Kalist (2004), who examined this context with different data and a slightly modified design, also found that Black women have substantially larger labor market effects than White women, though did find small effects of abortion legalization during the 1960s and 1970s in the United States for White women. These results were expanded upon by Mølland (2016) who documented substantial effects of abortion legalization on labor market participation across the life course for women: with around 2 pp higher rates of participation up to around the age of 35, at which point effects become negative, in line with reoptimized fertility timing. Similarly, in a U.S. setting Lindo et al. (2020b) documented that access to abortion increases the likelihood that women work in jobs with Social Security coverage early in life (in their 20s and 30s), with negative impacts later in life, reminiscent of the cyclicality documented by Mølland (2016). While the majority of this literature examined laws which liberalize access to abortion, Bahn et al. (2020) provided evidence from U.S. TRAP laws that reduced access. They found results that suggest that, conversely to the liberalizing effect of abortion availability, the targeting of abortion providers resulted in depressed labor market opportunities for women, specifically by reducing the ability that women have to move between jobs and access higher paying occupations.

Printed from Oxford Research Encyclopedias, Economics and Finance. Under the terms of the licence agreement, an individual user may print out a single article for personal use (for details see Privacy Policy and Legal Notice).
Subscriber: OUP-Reference Gratis Access; date: 20 June 2024

While the principal channel that likely explains these effects is greater flexibility to accumulate human capital and participate more freely in the labor market when fertility is more optimally timed, an additional channel has been noted in the economic literature. Chiappori and Oreffice (2008) noted that theoretically abortion legalization will increase bargaining power of women and, via an income effect, lead to increases in men's labor supply and declines in women's labor supply. Oreffice (2007) found support for this model empirically, noting immediate changes in the labor supply of men and women surrounding abortion legalization in the United States in the 1960s and 1970s. In the long run, any empowerment effect will be combined with effects flowing from additional human capital gains, meaning that these short-run effects will no longer be able to be identified cleanly; however, at least in the short run, Oreffice (2007) documented the existence of such effects.

Health Outcomes

There are a small number of studies considering the impacts of abortion availability on women's health outcomes. These are largely focused on reproductive health measures, with access to safe and legal abortion being convincingly found to reduce health complications and rates of maternal death. A clear example based on a reform was studied in Clarke and Mühlrad (2021), who considered the passage of legal abortion in Mexico City, in 2007. They documented declines in hospitalization both in examining rates of hemorrhage and abortion-related morbidity. They did not find evidence that contemporaneous increases in penalizations of abortion in other states in Mexico had any clear impact on rates of morbidity.

Evidence from an historical setting has been studied by Farin et al. (2023). Examining state-level changes in abortion law in the United States between 1969 and 1971 (pre-*Roe v. Wade*) and in 1973 (*Roe v. Wade*), they documented that the availability of legal abortion brought about declines in maternal mortality and abortion-related mortality in particular, and that this was driven by declines in mortality rates among non-White women. Both sets of results—those from Mexico considering morbidity and from the United States considering mortality—point to substantially sized impacts. Farin et al. (2023) found declines in non-White maternal mortality rates of between 30%–40%, while Clarke and Mühlrad (2021) found declines in morbidity of between 20%–35%. Strikingly, as a headline figure Farin et al. (2023) estimated that nationwide in the United States, 113 non-White maternal deaths where averted the first year that abortion was legalized, suggesting major welfare implications that cannot be ignored in any policy considerations related to abortion reform.

Gardner (2022) documented that the passage of TRAP laws in the United States, which restrict access to abortion, also result in estimable changes in health outcomes. Considering both maternal *and* child health, Gardner (2022) estimated that TRAP laws increase rates of pregnancy-associated hypertension and gestational diabetes (among other outcomes). Like a range of other U.S.-based studies, Gardner (2022) documented that the effects of abortion reform appear to impact Black women more than White women and noted a number of other distributional implications of policy reform.

Printed from Oxford Research Encyclopedias, Economics and Finance. Under the terms of the licence agreement, an individual user may print out a single article for personal use (for details see Privacy Policy and Legal Notice).
Subscriber: OUP-Reference Gratis Access; date: 20 June 2024

Other Outcomes

Abortion policies have also been documented to affect a number of other dimensions when focusing on cohorts of women exposed to reforms. These include empowerment, financial well-being, and life-satisfaction.

A particularly clean counterfactual for considering access to abortion is the "Turnaway" study, discussed in Miller et al. (2020, 2023). Based on gestational length limits and access to abortion, this study worked with a sample of women who requested abortions and were either just below the gestational length limit (a "near limit" group) or just over the gestational length limit (the "turn away" group). This study followed these two groups over a substantial period of time (5 years), leveraging the vastly different trajectories resulting from accessing or being turned away from abortion because of the gestational length limit. In Miller et al. (2023), these data are additionally matched to data on financial outcomes from credit reports. The authors found that when compared to the near limit group, the turn away group was observed to have substantially worse financial outcomes, being more likely to have overdue debts or to have suffered adverse events such as bankruptcy or eviction. What is more, these effects are observed to persist for an extended period.

A small number of studies have documented impacts of abortion reform on the empowerment of women. One such series of papers includes Chiappori and Oreffice (2008) and Oreffice (2007), who noted a theoretical channel whereby abortion legalization will empower women, with Oreffice (2007) documenting empirical results in support of this model. A handbook chapter by Bernstein and Jones (2021) noted more generally a range of findings linking women's reproductive health—including access to abortion—to empowerment.

Related to work on empowerment (as well as health and well-being), Muratori (2021) and Garcia-Ramos and Pineda Torres (2023) documented that abortion reform can directly impact rates of violence against women. In two separate contexts the authors noted that abortion access reduced rates of violence, while declines in access increased rates of violence. Muratori (2021) studied TRAP laws in the U.S. finding that increased distance to clinics resulted in increases in county-level rates of gender violence. Similarly, using a large survey focused on domestic violence, Garcia-Ramos and Pineda Torres (2023) found that liberalization of abortion in Mexico brought about declines in rates of violence.

Finally, results from González et al. (2018) suggest that abortion access may be relevant for women's self-reported life satisfaction. Using household survey data and subjective measures of life satisfaction, they found some evidence to suggest the women with greater access to abortion at younger ages are satisfied, at least when considering their living conditions and time devoted to leisure.

Printed from Oxford Research Encyclopedias, Economics and Finance. Under the terms of the licence agreement, an individual user may print out a single article for personal use (for details see Privacy Policy and Legal Notice).
Subscriber: OUP-Reference Gratis Access; date: 20 June 2024

How Does Abortion Reform Shape the Composition of Birth Cohorts?

A series of influential papers in the late 1990s and early 2000s brought into focus the question of how access to abortion shaped the characteristics of birth cohorts. If access to abortion implies that women and families are more likely to take intended pregnancies to term and not continue pregnancies that are unwanted, this would imply that children born after the legalization are more likely to have been planned and potentially exposed to different home environments and family investments. These ideas were formalized in Gruber et al.'s (1999) examination of the circumstances of cohorts of children at young ages, with later work of Donohue and Levitt (2001) considering the implications of this for later life outcomes (namely, crime rates). These papers have been followed by a substantial literature with the modeling implications of "abortion and selection" laid out in Ananat et al. (2009).

This focus on abortion and selection has precedents in earlier work. Kane and Staiger (1996) documented that restrictions in access to abortion in the United States led to declines in rates of teen births in the population, and Lundberg and Plotnick (1995) noted potentially divergent impacts of abortion reform by race in the United States, with both of these results suggestive that changes in abortion legislation will be reflected in changes in the mean characteristics of affected birth cohorts. Currie et al. (1996) additionally examined the impact of abortion restrictions on average health at birth of affected cohorts, suggesting that they observe weak evidence of a decline in birth weight. At an aggregate level Blank et al. (1996) documented that rates of abortion correlate with state-level economic factors as well as demographic factors, again potentially suggesting that changes in abortion laws will map into changes in cohort characteristics.

Conceptually, the impacts of abortion reform on cohorts could be due to a number of mechanisms. Pop-Eleches (2006) noted three principal mechanisms by which abortion policy may affect the composition of children. The first is an *unwantedness* channel: If children are more likely to be planned, parents may invest differentially or have more to invest in their children. The second is a *compositional* channel: If certain groups are more or less likely request an abortion, legalization of abortion will change the aggregate characteristics of families giving birth. And the third is a potential *crowding* channel: If abortion reform affects total cohort size, this may have some general equilibrium affects, such as more overcrowding in schools.

Abortion and Living Conditions

The impact of changes in abortion law on living conditions early in life have been documented in a number of papers and across settings. Studying variations in access to abortion in the 1970s in the United States, the work of Gruber et al. (1999) documented that the "marginal child" affected by abortion policy would have been at least 60% more likely to live in single parent households had abortion not been available, 50% more likely to live in poverty, 45% more likely to receive welfare, and 40% more likely to have died in the first year after birth. The early-life impacts of abortion legalization in this period was similarly documented in Ananat et al. (2009), who found that the immediate impacts of legalization in the United States in the 1970s was to reduce rates of teen motherhood among affected cohorts by 8.5% and reduce the likelihood of non-White births

Printed from Oxford Research Encyclopedias, Economics and Finance. Under the terms of the licence agreement, an individual user may print out a single article for personal use (for details see Privacy Policy and Legal Notice).
Subscriber: OUP-Reference Gratis Access; date: 20 June 2024

by 5.3%. Both sets of results can be considered to be estimates of the compositional channel, as they refer to how changes in usage of abortion across groups shape the characteristics of cohorts. What is more, these changes have been documented to have effects on hard measures of child well-being. Bitler and Zavodny (2001, 2002) showed that the legalization of abortion propelled declines in child abuse and neglect, with this result potentially owing to all three channels.

Impacts of abortion law on child living conditions have been documented in other contexts. Specifically, Mitrut and Wolff (2011) documented impacts of abortion legalization in Romania on child abandonment. They documented that following legalization of abortion in 1989, rates of child abandonment fell by around four children per 10,000 births, evidence of quite extreme impacts of abortion legalization on the living conditions of the marginal child in certain situations. The earlier criminalization of abortion in Romania has been comprehensively demonstrated to result in positive selection in terms of mothers' characteristics. Pop-Eleches (2006) documented that prior to the criminalization of abortion in 1966, mothers who were highly educated and who lived in urban areas were more likely to seek abortions, and as such, following criminalization, the proportion of children living in more educated and urban household increased (see also discussion in Hjalmarsson et al., 2021). It is noteworthy that in this particular case, the compositional effects are quite different to those documented with the passage of abortion laws in the United States in 1970s. In the United States, when abortion was legal, it was more common among socioeconomically disadvantaged groups (Gruber et al., 1999). In contrast, in Romania, the situation was reversed, with abortion being more prevalent among socioeconomically advantaged groups.

Characteristics of Cohorts in Adulthood

When considering outcomes later in life, a number of results have been documented. Early evidence from the U.S. presents clear results consistent with abortion legalization resulting in positive changes in mean life outcomes for cohorts when they reach maturity. Ananat et al. (2009) found that at around the age of 30, individuals from birth cohorts which were subject to legal abortion have a substantially lower likelihood of living in poverty, being a single parent, being on welfare, and not having graduated from college than cohorts in which abortion was not legally available. Charles and Stephens (2006), considering the same context and using data on substance abuse, documented lower rates of drug abuse among cohorts where abortion was available when these cohorts reach adolescence. In a non-U.S. context, Mølland (2016) found that the legalization of abortion in Norway similarly resulted in positive human capital outcomes for children of exposed cohorts at adulthood, both in terms of educational outcomes, labor market participation at age 30, and a reduced reliance on welfare. Gutierrez (2022) also documented that cohorts exposed to abortion at birth have impacts beyond human capital, finding that in Romania, children of mothers exposed to the abortion ban have significantly lower rates of fertility across their entire fertile life when they reach maturity.

A particularly clear case considering the multiple possible channels by which abortion may shape adult outcomes is found in a study by Pop-Eleches (2006). Examining the criminalization of abortion in Romania, he documented that at adulthood children of cohorts where sharp limits were in place restricting access to abortion had considerably *improved* outcomes in terms of

Printed from Oxford Research Encyclopedias, Economics and Finance. Under the terms of the licence agreement, an individual user may print out a single article for personal use (for details see Privacy Policy and Legal Notice).
Subscriber: OUP-Reference Gratis Access; date: 20 June 2024

education and labor market measures. This result is the opposite of what one may have suspected from the aforementioned studies, given that in the other contexts, following abortion legalization cohorts of mothers were observed to be—on average—more positively selected on socioeconomic status. However, Pop-Eleches (2006) documented that this result also owes to a compositional channel. In the case of Romania, he documented that where abortion was legal, individuals who accessed abortion were selectively more highly educated and more likely to live in urban areas. Thus, when abortion was legalized these individuals were relatively more likely to give birth, and as a result the composition of birth cohorts moved toward more highly educated mothers. A key result from the study by Pop-Eleches (2006) is that despite this selection channel, he was able to additionally document impacts of the unwantedness channel. In particular, he noted that when conditioning on the composition of mothers, effectively shutting off the compositional channel, he observed that the individuals born following the abortion ban had worse outcomes than similar individuals born prior to the abortion ban. Thus, in this particular setting Pop-Eleches (2006) was able to document the relevance of both of these channels, additionally showing that the nature of any compositional effects is context dependent.

Abortion, Child Circumstances, and Crime

Arguably one of the most visible debates in the economic literature of abortion has been given to questions related to abortion legalization and crime. Donohue and Levitt's (2001) landmark study proposed the "abortion–crime" hypothesis. Their paper proposed the theory that a decline in rates of homicides and other violent crime in the early 1990s in the United States may be largely explained by the legalization of abortion 2 decades earlier. This explanation coheres with the literature discussed in this section which suggests that abortion legalization resulted in substantial changes in characteristics of birth cohorts and broadly lines up with macrolevel trends in crime in the United States in the period in which the work was published. The original authors proposed a quite clear link between abortion legalization and crime (see e.g., Donohue & Levitt, 2020): namely (a) if children are not intended, they are at an elevated risk of facing unfavorable life circumstances including criminal involvement, (b) abortion reduces rates of unintended births, and (c) as a consequence, cohorts exposed to abortion should engage in less criminal activity. This argument makes clear that the selection channel, and in particular the argument relating to unwantedness, is key in mediating the proposed hypothesis.

Despite these broad facts in favor of the abortion–crime hypothesis, the estimated impact of abortion legalization on crime rates is very large (the authors estimated that abortion legalization may explain around half of the total crime reduction observed in the 1990s), and the empirical results underlying this paper have been questioned both in terms of a coding mistake in specific models (Foote & Goetz, 2008) as well as substantive contextual questions (Belloni et al., 2013; Foote & Goetz, 2008; Hjalmarsson et al., 2021; Joyce, 2004, 2009, for example). Reading across studies and contexts, it appears that the weight of the evidence in the literature suggests that the abortion–crime hypothesis—and especially the argument that "wantedness" of births results in declines in rates of crime—may not hold up to scrutiny. Nevertheless, the early work of Donohue and Levitt has propelled a considerable and still-active literature examining the abortion–crime hypothesis, capturing both academic and popular interest. This literature is substantial, and

Printed from Oxford Research Encyclopedias, Economics and Finance. Under the terms of the licence agreement, an individual user may print out a single article for personal use (for details see Privacy Policy and Legal Notice).
Subscriber: OUP-Reference Gratis Access; date: 20 June 2024

indeed, a number of papers provide broad overviews of the main findings and controversies. To capture the full nuance of the discussion and academic debate regarding the abortion–crime hypothesis, these papers are likely worthwhile starting points. Specifically, Joyce (2010) provided a handbook-length discussion of the first 10 years or so of debate on the abortion–crime hypothesis, proposing a number of key facts which appear to disprove the posited causal link, while Donohue and Levitt (2020) revisited their original work 20 years later suggesting original models still hold up. In the remainder of this section, the broad lines of this research are laid out, as well as key questions which challenge the veracity of the abortion–crime hypothesis.

The original paper by Donohue and Levitt (2001) examined the impact of state-level abortion rates that particular cohorts were exposed to at birth on rates of crime per capita and on raw total arrests by age group. For the period covering 1985–1997, they presented estimates which suggest that crime was between 15%–25% lower in 1997 than it would have been in the absence of legalized abortion. Given the total decline in crime during the 1990s, this result leads to the striking headline that the legalization of abortion can explain around half of the decline observed in violent crime over this period. This result has been questioned for a number of reasons. Foote and Goetz (2008) raised three concerns that range from coding errors in which state-year fixed effects were not included in regressions, to failure to account for rates in models examining total arrests. In Donohue and Levitt (2001), the log of total arrests by age group was regressed on abortion rates, and Foote and Goetz (2008) noted that when crime rates rather than total crimes are regressed on abortion rates, significant effects often do not remain. This appears to be an important point because the selection argument posits not that total criminal activity should fall but rather rates of criminal activity should fall; or in other words, that crime should not simply scale with any declines in cohort size due to the legalization of abortion. A second argument put forward by Joyce (2004) raised additional concerns: namely the possibility that unmeasured exposure to the crack cocaine epidemic may explain a substantial portion of the affect attributed to abortion on crime. The original authors have responded to these points suggesting that revised estimates still point to evidence in favor of their original hypothesis (Donohue & Levitt, 2004; Donohue & Levitt, 2008; Donohue & Levitt, 2020). Two other pieces of important evidence were raised in Joyce (2009) and Belloni et al. (2013). Joyce (2009) noted that if abortion availability alters cohort composition and crime rates, declines in crime should be observed differentially over time in cohorts progressively exposed to abortion legalization. Joyce (2009, 2010) documented that such cohort-specific patterns are not observed, a point similarly noted by Lott and Whitley (2007). Finally, Belloni et al. (2013) in a methodological paper introducing their postdouble selection estimator considered the abortion–crime hypothesis as an empirical example with which to apply their methods. When conducting variable selection using double-debiased machine learning techniques, they failed to find statistically significant effects of abortion legalization on changes in crime, noting that the hypothesis is thus sensitive to considerations of covariates included in Donohue and Levitt's (2001) original analysis.

Given that there is substantial debate related to the specific empirical example studied by Donohue and Levitt (2001; United States abortion legalization in the 1970s), to further clarify thinking on this issue it is useful to examine results from other contexts. Work by Hjalmarsson et al. (2021) studied the impact of the large changes in Romania's abortion policies on crime rates as

Printed from Oxford Research Encyclopedias, Economics and Finance. Under the terms of the licence agreement, an individual user may print out a single article for personal use (for details see Privacy Policy and Legal Notice).
Subscriber: OUP-Reference Gratis Access; date: 20 June 2024

an additional test of the abortion crime hypothesis.[7] In their setting, they considered both the criminalization of abortion in 1966 and the legalization of abortion in 1990. While they documented a large increase in rates of crime with the abolition of abortion and a decline in rates of crime with its legalization, it turns out that this effect was simply owed to changes in the number of births, with smaller cohorts mechanically committing less crime (and vice versa with larger cohorts). When considering rates, they found no evidence of changes in crime *rates*, leading them to conclude that any effect of abortion on crime in this setting is simply mechanical, rather than owing to any compositional or wantedness channels. Interestingly, a similar conclusion was reached by Ananat et al. (2009) in the United States, suggesting that any abortion–crime link is likely largely mechanical rather than owing to selection. There are a number of additional studies which have examined international experiences including Kahane et al. (2008; England and Wales), Kahane et al. (2008; Canada) and Buonanno et al. (2014) and François et al. (2014; panel of European countries and United States). Overall, these studies suggest mixed results with no clear consensus in these four settings.

In summary, despite a compelling hypothesis and multiple descriptive facts which appear to be consistent with the abortion–crime hypothesis, a number of highly credible papers suggest that this hypothesis should be viewed with considerable caution. While in multiple contexts there is strong evidence that abortion passage results in declines in the *absolute number* of crimes (consistent with smaller cohorts mechanically committing fewer crimes), the evidence in favor of a selection effect is much weaker, with a number of key tests that do not appear to suggest that changes in abortion rates drive down *rates* in crime.

Policy and Behavioral Interactions With Abortion Reform

A final point of interest in the economic literature on abortion reform is related to how individuals, policy makers, and policy more generally may interact with abortion reform. The discussion provided up to this point suggests that abortion reform may have substantial implications for individual outcomes in a partial equilibrium sense. However, it is of interest to consider what the ripples of abortion policy may be in a broader sense.

A small number of papers have studied how abortion reform interacts with available technologies and social norms. Two of these papers considered the routine availability of ultrasounds which are capable of reliably detecting fetal sex early in gestation. These papers (Anukriti et al., 2021; Lin et al., 2014) both take place in settings where there is a well-documented preference for sons, namely Taiwan and India. Lin et al. (2014) documented that the legalization of abortion in Taiwan in 1985 in a setting where sex-detecting technology is widely available increased the rate of boys born at higher parities and reduced rates of relative neonatal mortality among girls at higher parities. Anukriti et al. (2021) considered a similar interaction, however, in this case studying the introduction of ultrasound in a setting where abortion was already available and where sex-detecting ultrasound has been documented to substantially alter the gender composition of birth cohorts (Bhalotra & Cochrane, 2010). They found clear evidence that the interaction of these reforms improves the well-being of girls in a number of dimensions—most clearly reducing excess female mortality but also reducing disparities in the duration of breastfeeding of boys

Printed from Oxford Research Encyclopedias, Economics and Finance. Under the terms of the licence agreement, an individual user may print out a single article for personal use (for details see Privacy Policy and Legal Notice).
Subscriber: OUP-Reference Gratis Access; date: 20 June 2024

compared to girls and rates of vaccination of boys to girls. These policy interactions can be conceived as complementarities between abortion policy and ultrasound technologies. However, Goff et al. (2023) documented in quite a different setting that such complementarities do not occur when considering the interaction between abortion legalization and access to improved school environments. While they separately found that abortion reform and higher quality schools improve test scores, they did not find evidence of complementary interactions between improved home environments owing to abortion reform and higher school quality.

In general, these studies suggest that the implications of abortion policy may play out in a number of ways depending on the specific context of countries in which reforms occur. At times, the impacts of abortion policy decisions may result in unexpected and entirely undesired responses from individuals or policy makers. One such case is documented by Jones (2015) who studied the impact of the Global Gag Rule (GGR) in Ghana. While the GGR ostensibly aims to reduce rates of abortion by cutting U.S. aid funding for overseas nongovernmental organizations which provide information related to abortion, Jones (2015) documented that the policy has had the converse effect—it drives down access to a broad range of contraceptive methods, resulting in a corresponding increase in pregnancies, abortion, and birth rates. In another context, Clarke and Mühlrad (2021) noted that policy makers may respond to abortion policy outside their jurisdiction and themselves implement policy reform. They documented that progressive abortion policy in one state in Mexico led to a backlash in other states, at least in the short term, with criminal codes in other states being tightened to seek to further discourage access to clandestine abortion.

The effects of abortion policy have been shown to depend more generally on the way policy changes occur in space. A growing literature has shown that the way *local* (i.e., state-level) reforms work will depend more generally on interactions between each area and nearby localities. Specifically, where abortion restrictions are imposed in a subnational setting, the travel distance to the nearest available abortion provider has substantial impacts on both access to abortion and birth rates. Some discussion of this is provided in the section "Evidence on the Nature and Magnitude of Effects of Abortion Reform," and given a spate of state-level reforms in the United States over the last 2 decades, this question has attracted considerable attention. Overall, a range of papers have pointed to the costs of distance to the nearest abortion clinic being substantial, nonlinear, relevant both historically as well as at present, and depend considerably on individual characteristics. Work by Joyce et al. (2013) showed that in the 1970s in the United States, distance to the nearest available abortion clinic had an important impact on access to abortion. The authors suggested that a 100-mile increase in distance for women living around 180 miles from an abortion clinic reduced rates of abortion by 12.2%, whereas the same distance change for individuals living 830 miles away reduced rates of abortion 3.3%. Certain groups were found to be particularly sensitive to distance: in particular younger women and non-White women. Across a range of studies examining policy reforms, these results have been found to still be relevant (Fischer et al., 2018; Lindo et al., 2020a; Myers, 2023; Venator & Fletcher, 2020) both in terms of the magnitude of the effect on access to abortion as well as in finding the existence of substantial nonlinear effects. Using novel data on the location of abortion clinics as well as state-level reforms across the entire United States, Myers (2023) documented the importance of distance in both explaining abortion rates *as well* as explaining birth rates. Like impacts of distance on access

Printed from Oxford Research Encyclopedias, Economics and Finance. Under the terms of the licence agreement, an individual user may print out a single article for personal use (for details see Privacy Policy and Legal Notice).
Subscriber: OUP-Reference Gratis Access; date: 20 June 2024

to abortion, impacts on birth rates are found to be nonlinear. Myers (2023) documented that increasing distance to the nearest clinic by 100 miles increased birth rates by 2.2% for the first 100-mile increase, and this figure declined to 1.6% for the next 100-mile increase. Myers estimated that the costs of these changes in distance are largest for younger women, especially teens and individuals in their early 20s.

Finally, a number of studies have noted that individuals themselves may react to abortion policy altering their behaviors over a range of dimensions. One consideration is that individuals will react to abortion laws by reducing rates of sex. In considering parental involvement laws in the United States, which increase the challenges that teenagers face when seeking abortion, Colman et al. (2013), Levine (2003) and Sen (2006) did not find evidence consistent with teens reducing sexual behavior, but both Levine (2003); and Sabia and Anderson (2016) did find evidence consistent with these laws increasing usage of other birth control methods. These results are small, however, and do not suggest evidence of any large-scale substitution. In a related setting, Ananat and Hungerman (2012) documented evidence both at a micro- and state-level consistent with the availability of the oral contraceptive pill reducing young women's use of abortion. In general, there is mixed evidence related to any form of contraceptive substitution. More recently, when considering reductions in access to abortion clinics in Texas and all-age contraceptive purchase, Fischer et al. (2018) did not find any substantial response in terms of purchases of condoms or the emergency contraceptive pill. Crowe et al. (2023), conversely, reported that reductions in access to abortion in Texas following the implementation of TRAP laws resulted in increases of the use of certain types of long-acting reversible contraceptives among women, though they found no change in rates of vasectomies among men. In a similar line, Pennington and Venator (2023) suggested that contraceptives that are less-desired but that have lower failure rates were adopted after restrictions on abortion access were put in place in Wisconsin in 2015, and similar changes were observed following the 2016 U.S. presidential election given concerns related to future abortion access.

Conclusion

This review provides an overview of the state of economics research on abortion. It seeks to cover the range of abortion policies in place worldwide and provide a broad summary of the reforms studied in the economic literature, which have generally occurred from the 1960s onwards. It covers a number of key questions, ranging from a limited literature on the determinants of abortion reform to a substantially broader literature on the impacts of abortion policy on women, families, and cohorts of children. This research has largely been motivated by policy changes that have occurred in the late 20th and early 21st century and so has been more focused on liberalizing reforms to abortion policy in low fertility settings. Nevertheless, the literature covers a vast array of types of policy changes including a spate of restrictions in the early 2020s limiting both demand for and supply of abortion.

In the interest of space, the principal focus in this review has been on the economic literature on abortion. While this is a large field of study with a number of key themes and questions, this restriction necessarily reduces the breadth of questions and methods. A comprehensive review of

Printed from Oxford Research Encyclopedias, Economics and Finance. Under the terms of the licence agreement, an individual user may print out a single article for personal use (for details see Privacy Policy and Legal Notice).
Subscriber: OUP-Reference Gratis Access; date: 20 June 2024

abortion policy could productively draw on links with studies from reproductive health, public health, sociology, anthropology, legal studies, gender studies, demography, philosophy, and psychology, among other fields, although this is outside the scope of the current review.

Despite being a broad literature spanning multiple subfields of economics, open questions remain. One key point is that much of the extant literature in economics is driven off policy changes in a relatively small number of countries. Expanding the contexts studied will thus expand the frontier of knowledge in this area. Beyond expanding the scope of available evidence, the literature on the impacts of abortion policy will constantly evolve to the degree that policies and access to abortion continue to evolve. This has been clear with the uptick in studies examining TRAP laws in the United States, in line with their growing relevance in the policy landscape, as well as the very rapid diffusion of a number of papers following the United States Supreme Court decision to strike down *Roe v. Wade*. Future themes in abortion research will likely similarly track innovations and key changes in access. For example, themes such as the growing use of technologies like abortion pills, which can be taken at home and delivered by post; limits in access owing to global funding restrictions in aid directed to maternal and reproductive health; and the use of telemedicine services to bypass within-country restrictions are all potential areas of future fruitful work. The growing use of self-managed medicated abortion in particular is relevant both as a substantive research question as well as in seeking to understand whether lessons from past reforms can still inform thinking despite social and technical change.

Acknowledgments

The author is grateful to Kelly M. Jones, Mayra Pineda Torres and Caitlin Myers for very useful feedback and suggestions and to Francine Montecinos, Ignacio Fernández Sepúlveda, and Sebastián Fernández for outstanding research assistance. The very helpful comments of two anonymous referees are also acknowledged. The research support from ANID Chile, via FONDECYT regular grant 1200634 is gratefully acknowledged.

References

Altındağ, O., & Joyce, T. (2022). Another day, another visit: Impact of Arkansas' mandatory waiting period for women seeking an abortion by demographic groups. *Journal of Public Economics*, *213*, 104715.

Ananat, E. O., Gruber, J., & Levine, P. (2007). Abortion legalization and life-cycle fertility. *Journal of Human Resources*, *42*(2), 375–397.

Ananat, E. O., Gruber, J., Levine, P. B., & Staiger, D. (2009). Abortion and selection. *The Review of Economics and Statistics*, *91*(1), 124–136.

Ananat, E. O., & Hungerman, D. M. (2012). The power of the pill for the next generation: Oral contraception's effects on fertility, abortion, and maternal and child characteristics <https://doi.org/10.1162/REST_a_00230>. *The Review of Economics and Statistics*, *94*(1), 37–51.

Printed from Oxford Research Encyclopedias, Economics and Finance. Under the terms of the licence agreement, an individual user may print out a single article for personal use (for details see Privacy Policy and Legal Notice).
Subscriber: OUP-Reference Gratis Access; date: 20 June 2024

Angrist, J., & Evans, W. N. (1996, January). *Schooling and labor market consequences of the 1970 state abortion reforms* [NBER Working Paper Series 5406]. National Bureau of Economic Research.

Antón, J.-I., Ferre, Z., & Triunfo, P. (2018). The impact of the legalisation of abortion on birth outcomes in Uruguay. *Health Economics*, *27*(7), 1103–1119.

Anukriti, S., Bhalotra, S., & Tam, E. H. F. (2021). On the quantity and quality of girls: Fertility, parental investments and mortality. *The Economic Journal*, *132*(641), 1–36.

Arnold, G. (2022). The impact of targeted regulation of abortion providers laws on abortions and births. *Journal of Population Economics*, *35*(2), 1443–1472.

Bahn, K., Kugler, A., Mahoney, M. H., & McGrew, A. (2020). Do US TRAP laws trap women into bad jobs? *Feminist Economics*, *26*(1), 44–97.

Belloni, A., Chernozhukov, V., & Hansen, C. (2013). Inference on treatment effects after selection among high-dimensional controls. *The Review of Economic Studies*, *81*(2), 608–650.

Bernstein, A., & Jones, K. M. (2019). *The economic effects of abortion access: A review of the evidence* [Report]. Institute of Women's Policy Research & Center for Economics of Reproductive Health.

Bernstein, A., & Jones, K. M. (2021). Women's reproductive health and economic empowerment. In G. Berik & E. Kongar (Eds.), *The Routledge handbook of feminist economics* (pp. 330–338). Routledge.

Besley, T., & Case, A. (2000). Unnatural experiments? Estimating the incidence of endogenous policies. *The Economic Journal*, *110*(467), 672–694.

Bhalotra, S., Clarke, D., Gomes, J. F., & Venkataramani, A. (2023). Maternal mortality and women's political power <https://doi.org/10.1093/jeea/jvad012>. *Journal of the European Economic Association*, *21*(5), 2172–2208.

Bhalotra, S., Clots-Figueras, I., & Iyer, L. (2021). Religion and abortion: The role of politician identity. *Journal of Development Economics*, *153*, 102746.

Bhalotra, S., & Cochrane, T. (2010). *Where have all the young girls gone? Identification of sex selection in India* <https://econpapers.repec.org/RePEc:bri:cmpowp:10/254>. University of Bristol.

Bitler, M., & Zavodny, M. (2001). The effect of abortion restrictions on the timing of abortions. *Journal of Health Economics*, *20*(6), 1011–1032.

Bitler, M., & Zavodny, M. (2002, May). Child abuse and abortion availability. *American Economic Review*, *92*(2), 363–367.

Bitler, M., & Zavodny, M. (2004). Child maltreatment, abortion availability, and economic conditions. *Review of Economics of the Household*, *2*(2), 119–141.

Blank, R. M., George, C. C., & London, R. A. (1996). State abortion rates: The impact of policies, providers, politics, demographics, and economic environment. *Journal of Health Economics*, *15*(5), 513–553.

Bouton, L., Conconi, P., Pino, F., & Zanardi, M. (2021). The tyranny of the single-minded: Guns, environment, and abortion. *The Review of Economics and Statistics*, *103*(1), 48–59.

Printed from Oxford Research Encyclopedias, Economics and Finance. Under the terms of the licence agreement, an individual user may print out a single article for personal use (for details see Privacy Policy and Legal Notice).
Subscriber: OUP-Reference Gratis Access; date: 20 June 2024

Brooks, N., & Zohar, T. (2021, November). *Out of labor and into the labor force? The role of abortion access, social stigma, and financial constraints* [Working Papers wp2021_2111]. Centro de Estudios Monetarios y Financieros (CEMFI).

Buonanno, P., Drago, F., Galbiati, R., & Zanella, G. (2014). Crime in Europe and the United States: Dissecting the "reversal of misfortunes." *<https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1468-0327.2011.00267.x> Economic Policy*, *26*(67), 347–385.

Calkin, S. (2023). *Abortion pills go global: Reproductive freedom across Borders*. University of California Press.

Caraher, R. (2023). *Reproductive injustice? A county–level analysis of the impact of abortion restrictions on abortion rates* [Working Paper 573]. Political Economy Research Institute.

Center for Reproductive Rights. (2023). *The world's abortion laws <https://reproductiverights.org/maps/worlds-abortion-laws/>*.

Charles, K. K., & Stephens, M., Jr. (2006). Abortion legalization and adolescent substance use. *The Journal of Law and Economics*, *49*(2), 481–505.

Chiappori, P., & Oreffice, S. (2008). Birth control and female empowerment: An equilibrium analysis. *Journal of Political Economy*, *116*(1), 113–140.

Clarke, D., & Mühlrad, H. (2021). Abortion laws and women's health. *Journal of Health Economics*, *76*, 102413.

Colman, S., Dee, T. S., & Joyce, T. (2013). Do parental involvement laws deter risky teen sex? *Journal of Health Economics*, *32*(5), 873–880.

Colman, S., & Joyce, T. (2011). Regulating abortion: Impact on patients and providers in Texas. *Journal of Policy Analysis and Management*, *30*(4), 775–797.

Cook, P. J., Parnell, A. M., Moore, M. J., & Pagnini, D. (1999). The effects of short-term variation in abortion funding on pregnancy outcomes. *Journal of Health Economics*, *18*(2), 241–257.

Crowe, B., Gardner, G., & Haughey, C. (2023). *The effects of restricted abortion access on IUDs, contraceptive implants, and vasectomies: Evidence from Texas <https://grahamgardner.github.io/PaperRepository/LARC_Paper_ASHE.pdf>* [Working Paper, 6].

Currie, J., Nixon, L., & Cole, N. (1996). Restrictions on Medicaid funding of abortion: Effects on birth weight and pregnancy resolutions. *The Journal of Human Resources*, *31*(1), 159–188.

Dench, D., Pineda-Torres, M., & Myers, C. K. (2023, November 15). *The effects of the Dobbs decision on fertility <http://dx.doi.org/10.2139/ssrn.4634430>*, IZA Institute of Labor Economics, Discussion Paper 16608.

Dennis, A., Henshaw, S., Joyce, T., Finer, L., & Blanchard, K. (2009). *The impact of laws requiring parental involvement for abortion: A literature review*. Guttmacher Institute.

Donohue, J. J., III, & Levitt, S. D. (2001). The impact of legalized abortion on crime. *The Quarterly Journal of Economics*, *116*(2), 379–420.

Printed from Oxford Research Encyclopedias, Economics and Finance. Under the terms of the licence agreement, an individual user may print out a single article for personal use (for details see Privacy Policy and Legal Notice).
Subscriber: OUP-Reference Gratis Access; date: 20 June 2024

Donohue, J. J., III, & Levitt, S. D. (2008). Measurement error, legalized abortion, and the decline in crime: A response to Foote and Goetz. *The Quarterly Journal of Economics*, *123*(1), 425–440.

Donohue, J. J., & Levitt, S. (2020). The impact of legalized abortion on crime over the last two decades. *American Law and Economics Review*, *22*(2), 241–302.

Donohue, J. J., & Levitt, S. D. (2004). Further evidence that legalized abortion lowered crime: A reply to Joyce. *Journal of Human Resources*, *39*(1), 29–49.

Elías, J. J., Lacetera, N., Macis, M., & Salardi, P. (2017, May). Economic development and the regulation of morally contentious activities. *American Economic Review*, *107*(5), 76–80.

Farin, S. M., Hoehn-Velasco, L., & Pesko, M. (2023). The impact of legal abortion on maternal mortality *<https://www.aeaweb.org/articles?id=10.1257/pol.20220208&&from=f>*. *American Economic Journal: Economic Policy*.

Fischer, S., Royer, H., & White, C. (2018). The impacts of reduced access to abortion and family planning services on abortions, births, and contraceptive purchases. *Journal of Public Economics*, *167*, 43–68.

Foote, C. L., & Goetz, C. F. (2008). The impact of legalized abortion on crime: Comment. *The Quarterly Journal of Economics*, *123*(1), 407–423.

François, A., Magni-Berton, R., & Weill, L. (2014). Abortion and crime: Cross-country evidence from Europe. *International Review of Law and Economics*, *40*, 24–35.

Garcia-Ramos, A., & Pineda Torres, M. (2023). Access to abortion and intimate partner violence. *Mimeo*.

Gardner, G. (2022). *The maternal and infant health consequences of restricted access to abortion in the United States* *<https://grahamgardner.github.io/PaperRepository/Gardner_JMP.pdf>* [Working Paper].

Gius, M. (2019). Using the synthetic control method to determine the effect of ultrasound laws on state-level abortion rates. *Atlantic Economic Journal*, *47*, 205–215.

Goff, L., Malamud, O., Pop-Eleches, C., & Urquiola, M. (2023). Interactions between family and school environments *<https://jhr.uwpress.org/content/early/2023/04/03/jhr.0419-10143R2>*. *Journal of Human Resources*.

Gonzalez, F., & Quast, T. (2022). The relationship between abortion rates and economic fluctuations. *Economics & Human Biology*, *46*, 101120.

González, L., Jiménez-Martín, S., Nollenberger, N., & Vall-Castello, J. (2018, April). *The effect of abortion legalization on fertility, marriage and long-term outcomes for women* [BSE Working Paper 1035]. Barcelona School of Economics.

Green, D. P., Hyman-Metzger, O., Sood, G., & Zee, M. A. (2023). Revisiting a natural experiment: Do legislators with daughters vote more liberally on women's issues? *Journal of Political Economy Microeconomics*, *1*(3), 506–516.

Gruber, J., Levine, P., & Staiger, D. (1999). Abortion legalization and child living circumstances: Who is the "marginal child"? *The Quarterly Journal of Economics*, *114*(1), 263–291.

Gutierrez, F. H. (2022). The inter-generational fertility effect of an abortion ban. *Journal of Population Economics*, *35*(1), 307–348.

Printed from Oxford Research Encyclopedias, Economics and Finance. Under the terms of the licence agreement, an individual user may print out a single article for personal use (for details see Privacy Policy and Legal Notice).
Subscriber: OUP-Reference Gratis Access; date: 20 June 2024

Haas-Wilson, D. (1996). The impact of state abortion restrictions on minors' demand for abortions. *The Journal of Human Resources*, *31*(1), 140–158.

Hjalmarsson, R., Mitrut, A., & Pop-Eleches, C. (2021). The impact of abortion on crime and crime-related behavior. *Journal of Public Economics*, *200*, 104468.

Jacobson, M., & Royer, H. (2011, January). Aftershocks: The impact of clinic violence on abortion services. *American Economic Journal: Applied Economics*, *3*(1), 189–223.

Jones, K., & Pineda-Torres, M. (2021). *TRAP'd Teens: Impacts of abortion provider regulations on fertility & education* <https://econpapers.repec.org/RePEc:iza:izadps:dp14837> [IZA Discussion Papers 14837]. Institute of Labor Economics.

Jones, K., et al. (2021). *At a crossroads: The impact of abortion access on future economic outcomes* [Technical report], Department of Economics, American University.

Jones, K. M. (2015). Contraceptive supply and fertility outcomes: Evidence from Ghana. *Economic Development and Cultural Change*, *64*(1), 31–69.

Joyce, T. (2004). Did legalized abortion lower crime? *Journal of Human Resources*, *39*(1), 1–28.

Joyce, T. (2009). A simple test of abortion and crime. *The Review of Economics and Statistics*, *91*(1), 112–123.

Joyce, T. (2010). Abortion and crime: A review. In B. L. Benson & P. R. Zimmerman (Eds.), *Handbook on the economics of crime*. Edward Elgar.

Joyce, T. (2013). If only policy analysis were so easy. *Journal of Policy Analysis and Management*, *32*(4), 897–898.

Joyce, T., & Kaestner, R. (2001). The impact of mandatory waiting periods and parental consent laws on the timing of abortion and state of occurrence among adolescents in Mississippi and South Carolina. *Journal of Policy Analysis and Management*, *20*(2), 263–282.

Joyce, T., Tan, R., & Zhang, Y. (2013). Abortion before & after Roe. *Journal of Health Economics*, *32*(5), 804–815.

Joyce, T. J., Kaestner, R., & Ward, J. (2020). The impact of parental involvement laws on the abortion rate of minors. *Demography*, *57*(1), 323–346.

Kahane, L. H., Paton, D., & Simmons, R. (2008). The abortion–crime link: Evidence from England and Wales. *Economica*, *75*(297), 1–21.

Kalist, D. E. (2004). Abortion and female labor force participation: Evidence prior to Roe v. Wade. *Journal of Labor Research*, *25*(3), 503–514.

Kane, T. J., & Staiger, D. (1996). Teen motherhood and abortion access. *The Quarterly Journal of Economics*, *111*(2), 467–506.

Katz, L. F., & Goldin, C. (2002). The power of the pill: Oral contraceptives and women's career and marriage decisions. *Journal of Political Economy*, *110*(4), 7430–7770.

Printed from Oxford Research Encyclopedias, Economics and Finance. Under the terms of the licence agreement, an individual user may print out a single article for personal use (for details see Privacy Policy and Legal Notice).
Subscriber: OUP-Reference Gratis Access; date: 20 June 2024

Lahey, J. N. (2014a). Birthing a nation: The effect of fertility control access on the nineteenth-century demographic transition. *The Journal of Economic History*, *74*(2), 482–508.

Lahey, J. N. (2014b). The effect of anti-abortion legislation on nineteenth century fertility. *Demography*, *51*(3), 939–948.

Levine, P. B. (2003). Parental involvement laws and fertility behavior. *Journal of Health Economics*, *22*(5), 861–878.

Levine, P. B. (2004). *Sex and consequences: Abortion, public policy, and the economics of fertility*. Princeton University Press.

Levine, P. B., & Staiger, D. (2004). Abortion policy and fertility outcomes: The Eastern European experience. *The Journal of Law and Economics*, *47*(1), 223–243.

Levine, P. B., Trainor, A. B., & Zimmerman, D. J. (1996). The effect of Medicaid abortion funding restrictions on abortions, pregnancies and births. *Journal of Health Economics*, *15*(5), 555–578.

Lin, M.-J., Liu, J.-T., & Qian, N. (2014). More missing women, fewer dying girls: The impact of sex-selective abortion on sex at birth and relative female mortality in Taiwan <https://doi.org/10.1111/jeea.12091>. *Journal of the European Economic Association*, *12*(4), 899–926.

Lindo, J. M., Myers, C. K., Schlosser, A., & Cunningham, S. (2020a). How far is too far? New evidence on abortion clinic closures, access, and abortions. *Journal of Human Resources*, *55*(4), 1137–1160.

Lindo, J. M., & Pineda-Torres, M. (2021). New evidence on the effects of mandatory waiting periods for abortion <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jhealeco.2021.102533>. *Journal of Health Economics*, *80*, 102533.

Lindo, J. M., Pineda-Torres, M., Pritchard, D., & Tajali, H. (2020b, May). Legal access to reproductive control technology, women's education, and earnings approaching retirement <https://doi.org/10.1257/pandp.20201108>. *AEA Papers and Proceedings*, *110*, 231–235.

Lott, J. R., Jr., & Whitley, J. (2007). Abortion and crime: Unwanted children and out-of-wedlock births. *Economic Inquiry*, *45*(2), 304–324.

Lundberg, S., & Plotnick, R. D. (1995). Adolescent premarital childbearing: Do economic incentives matter? *Journal of Labor Economics*, *13*(2), 177–200.

Medoff, H. (2002). The determinants and impact of state abortion restrictions. *The American Journal of Economics and Sociology*, *61*(2), 481–493.

Miller, S., Wherry, L. R., & Foster, D. G. (2020, May). What happens after an abortion denial? A review of results from the Turnaway study. *AEA Papers and Proceedings*, *110*, 226–230.

Miller, S., Wherry, L. R., & Foster, D. G. (2023, February). The economic consequences of being denied an abortion. *American Economic Journal: Economic Policy*, *15*(1), 394–437.

Mitrut, A., & Wolff, F.-C. (2011). The impact of legalized abortion on child health outcomes and abandonment: Evidence from Romania. *Journal of Health Economics*, *30*(6), 1219–1231.

Printed from Oxford Research Encyclopedias, Economics and Finance. Under the terms of the licence agreement, an individual user may print out a single article for personal use (for details see Privacy Policy and Legal Notice).
Subscriber: OUP-Reference Gratis Access; date: 20 June 2024

Mølland, E. (2016). Benefits from delay? The effect of abortion availability on young women and their children. *Labour Economics*, *43*(1), 6–28.

Muratori, C. (2021, January). *The impact of abortion access on violence against women* <https://ideas.repec.org/p/rdg/emxxdp/em-dp2021-03.html> [Economics Discussion Papers em-dp2021-03]. University of Reading.

Myers, C. K. (2017). The power of abortion policy: Reexamining the effects of young women's access to reproductive control. *Journal of Political Economy*, *125*(6), 2178–2224.

Myers, C. K. (2021, June). *Cooling off or burdened? The effects of mandatory waiting periods on abortions and births* [IZA Discussion Papers 14434]. Institute of Labor Economics.

Myers, C. K. (2022). Confidential and legal access to abortion and contraception in the USA, 1960–2020. *Journal of Population Economics*, *35*(2), 1385–1441.

Myers, C. K. (2024). Forecasts for a post-Roe America: The effects of increased travel distance on abortions and births. *Journal of Policy Analysis and Management*, *43*, 39–62.

Myers, C. K., & Ladd, D. (2020). Did parental involvement laws grow teeth? The effects of state restrictions on minors' access to abortion. *Journal of Health Economics*, *71*, 102302.

Oreffice, S. (2007). Did the legalization of abortion increase women's household bargaining power? Evidence from labor supply. *Review of Economics of the Household*, *5*(2), 181–207.

Pennington, K., & Venator, J. (2023). *Reproductive policy uncertainty and defensive investments in contraception* <https://static1.squarespace.com/static/5c51b33a5417fc03ad2b3fdb/t/656657559064433549000 07e/1701205866072/Pennington_Venator_2023.pdf> [Working Paper].

Pop-Eleches, C. (2006). The impact of an abortion ban on socioeconomic outcomes of children: Evidence from Romania. *Journal of Political Economy*, *114*(4), 744–773.

Pop-Eleches, C. (2010). The supply of birth control methods, education, and fertility evidence from Romania. *Journal of Human Resources*, *45*(4), 971–997.

Sabia, J. J., & Anderson, D. M. (2016). The effect of parental involvement laws on teen birth control use. *Journal of Health Economics*, *45*, 55–62.

Sedgh, G., Singh, S., Shah, I. H., Åhman, E., Henshaw, S. K., & Bankole, A. (2012). Induced abortion: Incidence and trends worldwide from 1995 to 2008. *The Lancet*, *379*(9816), 625–632.

Sen, A. (2007). Does increased abortion lead to lower crime? Evaluating the relationship between crime, abortion, and fertility. *The BE Journal of Economic Analysis & Policy*, *7*(1), 1–38.

Sen, B. (2006). Frequency of sexual activity among unmarried adolescent girls: Do state policies pertaining to abortion access matter? *Eastern Economic Journal*, *32*(2), 313–330.

Valente, C. (2014). Access to abortion, investments in neonatal health, and sex-selection: Evidence from Nepal. *Journal of Development Economics*, *107*, 225–243.

Printed from Oxford Research Encyclopedias, Economics and Finance. Under the terms of the licence agreement, an individual user may print out a single article for personal use (for details see Privacy Policy and Legal Notice).
Subscriber: OUP-Reference Gratis Access; date: 20 June 2024

van der Meulen Rodgers, Y. (2018). *The global gag rule and women's reproductive health: Rhetoric versus reality*. Oxford University Press.

van der Meulen Rodgers, Y., Coast, E., Lattof, S. R., Poss, C., & Moore, B. (2021). The macroeconomics of abortion: A scoping review and analysis of the costs and outcomes. *PLoS ONE*, *16*(5), e0250692.

Van Effenterre, C. (2020). Papa does preach: Daughters and polarization of attitudes toward abortion. *Journal of Economic Behavior & Organization*, *179*, 188–201.

Venator, J., & Fletcher, J. (2020). Undue burden beyond Texas: An analysis of abortion clinic closures, births, and abortions in Wisconsin. *Journal of Policy Analysis and Management*, *40*(3), 774–813.

Washington, E. L. (2008, March). Female socialization: How daughters affect their legislator fathers. *American Economic Review*, *98*(1), 311–332.

Notes

1. Research has pointed to evidence that these results may be time- and context-specific, with Green et al. (2023) not observing similar patterns if extending to earlier and later Congresses to those studied by Washington (2008).

2. This law was named after Simone Veil, the Health Minister who drafted the bill that legalized abortion, permitting abortion on request up to the tenth gestational week.

3. Caitlin Myers is acknowledged for suggesting the inclusion of this point in this review.

4. Due to space limitations, the substantial literature on abortion policy outside of economic journals is not reviewed here.

5. In certain settings, proxies have been proposed as a noisy way to measure access to abortion procedures. For example, Pop-Eleches (2010) noted that in cases where abortion is illegal, and given risks inherent in clandestine abortion, maternal mortality is a proxy of access to clandestine abortion in the absence of safe alternatives.

6. These are defined as marriages which are followed by a birth within the next 8 months.

7. Pop-Eleches (2006) also touched on this debate, however, Hjalmarsson et al. (2021) was focused exclusively on the abortion–crime link and interacted closely with Pop-Eleches (2006), and so the Hjalmarsson et al. study is discussed here.

Related Articles

The Effects of Prenatal Care on Birth Outcomes: Reconciling a Messy Literature

Missing Women: A Review of Underlying Causes and Policy Responses

Printed from Oxford Research Encyclopedias, Economics and Finance. Under the terms of the licence agreement, an individual user may print out a single article for personal use (for details see Privacy Policy and Legal Notice).
Subscriber: OUP-Reference Gratis Access; date: 20 June 2024